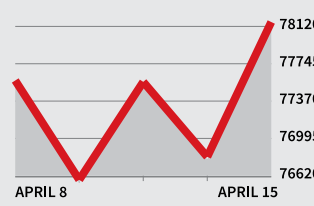


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78111.24 (+1263.67)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24231.30	+388.65
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.46	+0.34
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.37	-0.01
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	152253.00	+2843
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	249019.00	+12038

POLLSCAPE.

Southern states ramp up resistance to delimitation exercise, with election-bound Tamil Nadu leading from the front **p5**



TECHNOPHILE.

Samsung Galaxy S26 exudes a premium vibe with an elegant design **p4**

QUICKLY.

BEST DAY IN WEEKS

Sensex gains 1,264 points, Nifty settles at 24,231

Mumbai: Markets surged on Wednesday, delivering their strongest session in weeks, as geopolitical optimism, falling oil prices and buoyant global cues triggered buying. The Sensex closed at 78,111.24, gaining 1,263.67 points, while the Nifty 50 settled at 24,231.30 — its highest close since March 10. **p8**

DEFICIT WIDENS

Merchandise exports grow by over 4% in FY26

New Delhi: Merchandise exports grew by over 4 per cent in the 2025-26 fiscal year, though the overall trade deficit widened by more than 26 per cent for the full year, according to data released by the Commerce Ministry on Wednesday. Despite the annual expansion of the gap, the trade deficit narrowed in March. **p3**

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Mehli Mistry seeks appointment of administrator in Sir Dorabji Tata Trust

GRAVE VIOLATIONS. Former trustee alleges illegalities in the running and governance of the Trust

Raghuvir Srinivasan
Chennai

Mehli Mistry, who stepped down from the Tata Trusts as a trustee in November last year after being denied re-appointment, has alleged grave illegalities in the administration of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and prayed for the appointment of an Administrator to run the trust.

In a filing on Wednesday before the Charity Commissioner, Mumbai, seen by *businessline*, Mistry questioned the legality of the Board of Trustees, arguing that appointments in the recent past were made in violation of Section 30A of the Maharashtra Public Trust Act, 1950.

The Board of Trustees now comprises Noel Tata (Chairman), Venu Srinivasan (Vice Chairman), Vijay Singh, Darius Khambata, Bhaskar Bhat and Neville Tata. The last two were appointed in place of Mehli Mistry and Pramit Jhaveri, who stepped down in February.

Interestingly, Mistry has

declared that he has “no desire” to rejoin the Trust board but that it should be run by “able, honest Trustees or an Administrator”.

Earlier this month, Mistry had filed an objection with the Charity Commissioner against the presence of Srinivasan and Singh as trustees on the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution on grounds of their not being Parsis and residents of Mumbai, as required by the trust deed.

ILLEGAL BOARD

Objecting to the Change Report filed by SDTT after his exit and the entry of new trustees, Mistry contested his non-renewal as a trustee, arguing that it violated a 2024 resolution for mutual perpetual reappointments among trustees of SDTT and the other major trust, Sir Ratan Tata Trust.

Mistry contended that the board that voted him out was illegal as the appointment to perpetuity of Noel Tata and Srinivasan on the board was in violation of Section 30A of Maharashtra Public Trusts Act.

The said section was in-



(from left) Mehli Mistry, Noel Tata and Venu Srinivasan

roduced into the Act by the Maharashtra government on September 1, 2025, and it placed statutory restrictions, prescribed governance norms relating to the manner of reappointment of trustee, limits on tenure and limitations on appointment of perpetual trustees.

An email sent to Tata Trusts CEO Siddharth Sharma for his reaction remained unanswered until the time of going to press.

GOVERNANCE FAILURE

Alleging that the governance of the trusts had been seriously compromised, Mistry named two trustees in his filing for what he called “illegal acts”.

The first pertains to Singh,

who is alleged to have pocketed commissions and sitting fees from Tata Sons and other Tata Group companies totalling ₹20.13 crore.

“A trustee is bound by strict fiduciary duties to act solely in the best interests of the trust and to avoid any conflict of interest. The receipt of substantial financial benefits by a trustee from entities connected with the trusts is *prima facie* inconsistent with such obligations,” Mistry’s filing said.

Mistry also alleged that there were other trustees who were receiving monetary or other personal benefits from their positions.

Asked for his reaction, Singh told *businessline*: “I will not respond. The Tata

Trusts will respond with facts to any queries from the Charity Commissioner.”

JLR AND NORTON

In a more serious conflict of interest allegation aimed at Srinivasan, Mistry alleged in the objection filing that Srinivasan and his son engaged Gerry McGovern, the COO of Jaguar Land Rover Brand & Luxury, as a consultant for Norton Motorcycles, a subsidiary of TVS Holdings.

He alleged that this was a breach of fiduciary duties as a trustee and nominated director on the Tata Sons board and pleaded for the Charity Commissioner to direct disclosure by Srinivasan if he had paid Jaguar Land Rover for utilising the services of McGovern.

Responding to the allegation, a senior official of the TVS group told *businessline* that the late Ratan Tata and Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran were aware of the engagement of McGovern by Norton. He said McGovern mentored Norton, and it was approved by the top management of Jaguar Land Rover.

Crucial Air India meeting to focus on leadership flux and profitability push

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Top executives of Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines are set to meet on Thursday as Air India navigates leadership flux following CEO Campbell Wilson’s resignation, alongside an estimated loss of around ₹20,000 crore for FY26, sources told *businessline*.

The meeting assumes significance as the airline plans a leadership transition.

Besides, the two stakeholders in Air India might take a call on the airline’s request for additional funds in the range of over ₹10,000 crore to tide over the current operating environment.

According to sources, the discussions are likely to centre around new leadership, execution priorities and accelerating the path to profitability.

ENSURING STABILITY

The alignment between the two stakeholders is seen as crucial in ensuring stability during the transition.

Sources said that the financial situation of the airline will be closely analysed, and a course correction might be initiated.

Air India’s losses are re-



portedly pegged around ₹20,000 crore for FY26 due to airspace restrictions, costly jet fuel and a depreciating rupee.

The current financial situation underlines the pressure on the balance sheet and might impact ongoing investments in fleet and service upgrades.

Singapore Airlines, which holds a 25 per cent stake in the airline, is expected to play a key role in shaping the strategy, leveraging its operational expertise and global network, sources said.

The discussions, sources said, may explore deeper collaboration, including expanded commercial arrangements and closer operational alignment between the two airlines beyond their home markets.

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QUICKLY.

Jeh Aerospace inks pact with Liebherr-Aerospace



Hyderabad: Jeh Aerospace has signed a five-year long-term agreement (LTA) with Liebherr-Aerospace to manufacture and supply high-precision components for landing gear systems on high-rate commercial single-aisle aircraft programmes. Under the agreement, Jeh Aerospace will manufacture and supply these components from its Hyderabad facility, becoming part of France-based Liebherr-Aerospace's global industrial network. Landing gear production is among the most demanding disciplines in aerospace manufacturing — components must meet extremely tight dimensional tolerances, pass rigorous qualification standards, and be delivered with no margin for disruption. **OUR BUREAU**

Insurers need to make payouts quick and frictionless: DFS Secy

PRESSURE POINTS. Customers face extensive scrutiny, queries and procedural hurdles

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Insurers needed to make quick and frictionless payouts during claims and at the time of policy maturity to foster greater trust between the insurer and the insured, said M Nagaraju, Secretary, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance.

“While taking the policy, you do not ask any questions... but while redemption comes, they will ask you 100 questions,” said Nagaraju, at the launch of two apps by the Life Insurance Corporation of India, one for customers and another for agents.

At the time of onboarding, insurance companies were primarily concerned with collecting premiums, he said, while at the time of redemptions customers are subjected to extensive scrutiny, re-

LIC must urgently modernise to stay relevant in a rapidly evolving financial ecosystem

M NAGARAJU
Secretary, Department of Financial Services



peated queries, and procedural hurdles such as multiple KYC requirements. This, he implied, creates a perception of mistrust and undermines the very confidence that institutions like LIC have built over decades.

Drawing a parallel with banking, he said that just as a fixed deposit is automatically credited to a customer's account upon maturity without unnecessary intervention, insurance payouts too should be far more seam-

less, prompt, and trust driven.

MODERNISING LIC
He also said LIC must urgently modernise to stay relevant in a rapidly evolving financial ecosystem. He pointed out that while banks have invested heavily in digital infrastructure over the past two decades, insurance companies have lagged behind.

The ‘MyLIC’ app for customers launched by the

state-owned insurer would help policy holders manage their insurance portfolio right from KYC at onboarding, paying premiums on time, reviving lapsed policies to even availing loans against their policies.

SUPER SALES SAATHI
The ‘Super Sales Saathi’ app for insurance agents would help them in keeping track of their customers and their policies, communicate with them; it comes with dashboards to monitor their performance as well.

LIC CEO & MD R Doraiswamy said as part of the digital push, the insurance company was moving from a fragmented system of 113 divisional databases to a unified data lake, which will enable AI and machine learning applications, including predictive underwriting, fraud detection, customer targeting, and renewal nudges.

Women under-represented in Assemblies and Parliament

Yashaswani Chauhan
Aleena Rose Jose
New Delhi

Ahead of a special three-day Parliamentary session to advance the Women's Reservation Bill, a look at recent election results show women remain significantly under-represented as candidates and elected lawmakers.

DATA FOCUS.

The share of women MPs in the Lok Sabha has risen gradually over the past two decades, though gains remain modest. Women accounted for 7.98 per cent of Lok Sabha MPs in 2004. The proportion rose to 10.7 per cent in 2009, 11.46 per cent in 2014, and peaked at 14.39 per cent in 2019. In 2024, women comprised 13.63 per cent of Lok Sabha MPs.

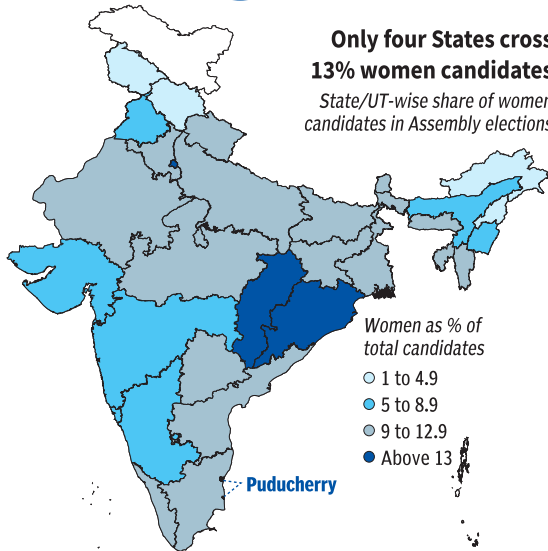
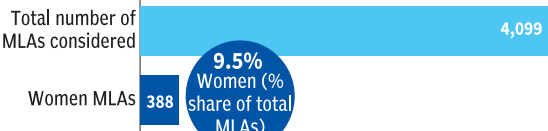
388 MLAs
Analysis of recent Assembly elections shows women constituted 9.5 per cent of total MLAs. Of 4,099 MLAs, only 388 were women. Data suggest even when women contest, their success rate remains limited relative to overall representation. On the candidature front, the picture is similarly constrained. Only four States/UTs crossed the 13 per cent mark in women's share among total candidates. Odisha (13.9 per cent) topped the list, followed by Puducherry (13.7 per cent), Delhi (13.7 per cent), and Chhattisgarh (13.1 per cent).

At the lower end, Nagaland recorded the lowest share at 2.2 per cent. Arunachal Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir were at 4.9 per cent each, while Himachal Pradesh stood at 5.8 per cent. In most large States, including Maharashtra (8.8 per cent), Gujarat (8.5 per cent), and Karnataka (7.1 per cent), women remained below the 10 per cent threshold. Party-wise data based on the 18th Lok Sabha and sitting MLAs in current Assemblies show most major political parties have around 10 per cent women legislators.

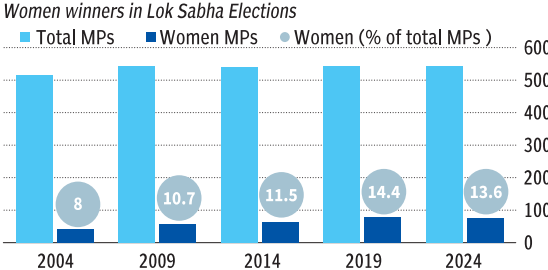
The BJP has 10.34 per cent women among its MPs and MLAs combined, while the Indian National Congress stands at 9.52 per cent. The

Why reservation for women

Women constituted 9.5% of total MLAs in recent Assembly elections



Number of female Lok Sabha MPs rises



Most major parties have around 10% women lawmakers; AITC leads at 18%

Party-wise women MPs and MLAs
Based on 18th Lok Sabha MPs and sitting MLAs in current Assemblies

Party	Men MPs/MLAs	Women MPs/MLAs	Women (% share of total MPs/MLAs)
BJP	1,683	194	10.3
INC	684	72	9.5
AITC	204	45	18.1
TDP	130	21	13.9
SP	132	19	12.6

Source: ADR

All India Trinamool Congress leads with 18.07 per cent. The Telugu Desam Party (13.91 per cent) and the Samajwadi Party (12.58 per cent) are also above the 10 per cent mark.

Women's representation is significantly higher at the grassroots level due to constitutional mandates. Article 243D provides reservation for women in Panchayats, and 21 States and two Union Territories have raised this quota to 50 per cent. As a res-

ult, several States report women accounting for over half of elected representatives in Panchayati Raj Institutions (2024), including Uttarakhand (56 per cent), Andhra Pradesh (55.5 per cent), and Chhattisgarh (55 per cent).

In contrast, some regions remain near the one-third mark, such as Uttar Pradesh (33.3 per cent) and Jammu & Kashmir (33.2 per cent).

Aleena Rose Jose is an intern

Tata Motors faces tougher FY27 at home

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Tata Motors is entering FY27 with two parallel priorities: closing a global deal that could reshape its scale and navigating a domestic market that is turning more unpredictable.

The company is targeting a first-quarter close for its Iveco acquisition, according to top industry sources, subject to regulatory approvals.

Executive Director Girish Wagh declined to comment on specifics but said a transaction is awaiting approvals and would move forward as it is awaiting some cross-border approvals, adding the company was “keeping its fingers crossed”.

That global ambition comes even as the company's core commercial vehicle (CV) business, fresh off a

strong FY26, faces a more complex operating environment at home.

STRONG FY26, BUT...
Tata Motors' CV business grew 14 per cent to 428,329 units in FY26, its highest since FY21. But the headline number masks a split year: a flat first half followed by a sharp recovery in the second.

The rebound was driven by GST-led freight efficiency, sustained infrastructure spending and a delayed fleet replacement cycle. Medium and heavy CV volumes surged, while passenger carriers and electric CVs also saw strong growth.

Industry analysts say margins held at 11–12 per cent despite the weak first half, reflecting a conscious decision to avoid aggressive discounting.

The bigger question now is not demand but its durab-



ility. “Underlying demand remains strong... but sentiment has turned cautious,” Wagh said, pointing to healthy order pipelines even after recent global disruptions. Two emerging risks are shaping that caution: diesel prices and export uncertainty.

“The most important monitorable is diesel prices,” Wagh said, noting that any sustained increase would directly raise operating costs for fleet owners and delay purchase decisions.

That sensitivity is now intersecting with develop-

ments in export markets.

West Asia a key destination for Indian CV exports, has seen immediate disruption following the recent crisis. However, Tata does not yet see a structural shift in demand.

“There is no shift, we'll have to see the longer-term impact,” Wagh said.

The impact remains uneven. While markets such as Sri Lanka are seeing sharper pressure, Africa has held relatively steady, suggesting that exports are softening at the margins rather than weakening broadly. To-

Lucknow plant ‘to make mobility more sustainable’

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

As the company advances its net-zero journey, Tata Motors on Wednesday said its Lucknow plant will continue to play a pivotal role in shaping a cleaner, smarter and more sustainable mobility future for India. The country's largest commercial vehicle manufacturer has marked a milestone with the rollout of 10 lakh commercial vehicles from its Lucknow facility, commemorating more than three-and-a-half decades of its presence in Uttar Pradesh and its contribution to industrial excellence, economic growth,



GREENER RIDES. Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath

skill development and sustained livelihood creation, the company stated. At a time when India's commercial vehicle industry is undergoing rapid transformation towards cleaner, smarter and more efficient mobility solutions, this milestone

underscores Tata Motors' leadership in shaping the future of mobility, it added. “As Uttar Pradesh accelerates its journey towards sustainable and inclusive growth, we remain firmly committed to contributing to its progress and to

shaping a future-ready mobility ecosystem,” N Chandrasekaran, Chairman, Tata Sons, said.

MILESTONE VEHICLE
The milestone vehicle, a zero-emission electric bus, highlighted the shared commitment of Uttar Pradesh and Tata Motors to green mobility, aligned with the State's net-zero 2070 vision and the company's net-zero target of 2045, he added. Meanwhile, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said that no external elements should be allowed to interfere in factory operations, asserting that such interference can disrupt industrial harmony and

progress. “Our vision is to transform Uttar Pradesh into a one-trillion-dollar economy, with industry and entrepreneurs playing a pivotal role in this journey.

The State offers a conducive ecosystem for scalable businesses, supported by a vast consumer market, a young, skilled workforce, and seamless connectivity,” he said.

Tata Motors' success in UP reflects the strength of this ecosystem and reinforces the State's commitment to fostering responsible industrial growth, creating jobs, building skills and advancing sustainable socio-economic development, he added.

Nuvoco Vistas to acquire 26% stake in CleanMax Enviro Energy SPV

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Nuvoco Vistas Corporation Ltd, the cement arm of the Gujarat-based Nirma Group, has approved an investment of up to ₹26 crore to acquire a 26 per cent stake in Clean Max Ilghop Private Ltd, a special purpose vehicle (SPV) set up by a Mumbai-based independent power producer (IPP) Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions Ltd.

The investment is aimed at setting up a captive hybrid renewable energy power



plant at Bhikamkhore district in Jodhpur, Rajasthan, on a build-own-operate-transfer (BOOT) basis.

The project will supply green energy to Nuvoco's Nimbol cement plant.

for the acquisition. The long-term nature of the project is reflected in the 25-year operational framework.

The investment will be made through cash consideration, with the transaction structured via multiple agreements, including a shareholders' agreement, share purchase agreement, energy supply agreement and power purchase agreement. Following the acquisition, Clean Max Ilghop will become an associate company of Nuvoco.

RE SOLUTIONS
Clean Max Ilghop Private Ltd was incorporated in October 2025, in India.

The company operates in the electric power generation, transmission and distribution sector, with a focus on renewable energy solutions.

As a newly incorporated entity, Clean Max Ilghop has reported no turnover for the last three years.

Govt subsidy will help early EV adoption: VinFast

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Vietnamese EV major VinFast on Wednesday threw its weight behind government-led financial incentives, stating subsidies are a critical catalyst for early-stage EV adoption. It urged State governments across India to implement supportive frameworks, pointing to the recently released Delhi EV Policy 2026 as a benchmark for the industry.

VinFast, which is preparing to launch its India operations with a focus on local manufacturing, emphasised that targeted policies significantly lower the entry barrier for consumers.

“So, if the government – be it two-wheeler or four-wheeler, be it the Central government or State governments – gives incentives, it is going to be beneficial for the early EV adoption – and it will really help... We are committed to a greener planet, to



NEW ADDITION. The company launched its VF MPV 7 electric multi-purpose vehicle at ₹24.49 lakh (ex-showroom)

a greener society and to an overall sustainable ecosystem,” Tapan Ghosh, Chief Executive Officer, VinFast India, told reporters here.

NEW PRODUCT VF MPV 7
Speaking on the sidelines of the launch of its new product, VF MPV 7, Ghosh said that is why VinFast gave up manufacturing internal combustion engine (ICE) powered vehicles since 2020-21, and only manufacturers EVs, whether two or four-

wheeler, even though the penetration is low right now.

“We also know that right now the penetration of EV in two-wheeler is may be around 7 per cent and in four-wheeler it is 4-5 per cent, so there is big room to catch up... Delhi government's step is very encouraging because if like Delhi other State governments also do similar things where customers are given that benefit to adopt EVs, it is going to benefit all three stake-

holders: the government in oil import bills, public with a greener society, and the customers in running cost and maintenance,” he said.

Talking about the company's upcoming launch on electric two-wheelers, Ghosh said that VinFast will not launch low-cost electric two-wheelers, and just like its electric cars, the company will launch premium two-wheelers by end of this year.

VinFast is talking to dealers for the electric two-wheelers now, and initially it will bring completely knocked down (CKD) units, same as its four-wheeler EVs, he added.

The company launched VF MPV 7 electric multi-purpose vehicle priced at ₹24.49 lakh (ex-showroom). The new EV in its portfolio is powered by a 60.13 kWh lithium-ion battery that has a range of 517 km on a full charge (ARAI certified), and delivers 150 kW and 280 Nm of torque via front-wheel drive.

ICICI Lombard profit up on health growth

Reuters

ICICI Lombard General Insurance reported a 7 per cent rise in fourth-quarter profit on Wednesday on strong demand for its retail health insurance products.

The insurer's profit after tax rose to ₹547 crore for the three months ended March 31, from ₹510 crore a year ago.

Analysts expected general insurers to deliver a strong March quarter on growth in the health and motor segments.

ICICI Lombard's retail health insurance premiums surged 55.6 per cent year-on-year, outpacing a 9.9 per cent rise in its corporate health segment.

Meanwhile, motor insurance, its largest segment, accounting for nearly half of total premiums, grew 6.24 per cent for the quarter on strong vehicle sales.

QUICKLY.

Non-life insurance sector grows 9.2% in FY26

Hyderabad: The gross direct premium (GDP) underwritten by non-life insurers increased 9.2 per cent in the financial year ended March 2026 at ₹3.35 lakh crore compared to ₹3.07 lakh crore in the previous financial year. As per figures released by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), the total GDP in FY26 stood at ₹3,35,918 crore, up from ₹3,07,612 crore. The GDP of general insurers grew 7.86 per cent to ₹2,78,376 crore from ₹2,58,090 crore. The GDP of standalone private health insurers surged 19.8 per cent at ₹45,865 crore (₹38,413 crore). **OUR BUREAU**

Credit-deposit ratio of banks widens to 255 bps

Mumbai: The credit-deposit ratio of all scheduled banks widened to about 255 basis points as of March-end 2026 from about 91 bps as on April 4, 2025, amid credit growth outpacing deposit growth, going by latest RBI data. As of March-end 2026, credit and deposit growth of these banks stood at 15.96 per cent and 13.41 per cent, respectively. As of April 4, 2025, all scheduled banks' credit and deposit growth stood at 10.9 per cent and 9.99 per cent, respectively. **OUR BUREAU**

Exports grow 4% to \$860 b in FY26, imports up at \$979 b

KEY INDICATORS. Trade deficit widens by around \$25 billion, amid global headwinds

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Merchandise exports grew by over 4 per cent in the 2025-26 fiscal year, though the overall trade deficit widened by more than 26 per cent for the full year, according to data released by the Commerce Ministry on Wednesday.

Despite the annual expansion of the gap, the trade deficit narrowed in March as both exports and imports saw a synchronised dip during the final month of the fiscal year.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said India's exports are doing well despite challenges. Merchandise exports during April-March 2025-26 went up 1 per cent to \$441.78 billion from \$437.7 billion. Imports also increased to \$774.98 billion during the period from \$721.2 billion in 2024-25. Services exports are estimated at \$418.31 billion in 2025-26, showing a growth of around 8 per cent. For March, India's total exports (merchandise and services combined) are estimated at \$74.11 billion, registering a negative growth



Trade data

		2024-25	2025-26	% change
		(\$ billion)		
Merchandise	Export	437.7	441.78	0.9
	Import	721.2	774.98	7.5
Services*	Export	387.55	418.31	7.9
	Import	198.72	204.42	2.9
Total	Export	825.26	860.09	4.2
	Import	919.92	979.4	6.5
Trade deficit		94.66	119.3	26.0

*Estimated Source: Commerce Ministry

of (-)4.58 per cent as against March 2025. Total imports (merchandise and services combined) for March 2026 are estimated at \$76.55 billion, registering a negative growth of (-) 5.76 per cent as against March 2025. Accordingly, trade deficit narrowed to \$2.44 billion as against \$3.55 billion in March.

EXPORTS TO W. ASIA DIP
Due to the war involving the US, Israel and Iran, which began on February 28, ex-

ports to West Asia fell 57.95 per cent in March, Agrawal said, adding that total imports from that region also declined by 51.64 per cent last month.

Imports of crude oil and related products fell nearly 36 per cent year-on-year to \$12.18 billion in March, while gold imports declined 31.6 per cent to \$3.06 billion.

Commenting on the yearly data, SC Ralhan, President of FIEO, said: "Crossing \$860 billion in exports is

a notable achievement, particularly amid global uncertainties, supply chain disruptions and fluctuating demand. It highlights the adaptability and strength of Indian exporters."

GROWTH DRIVERS

He said export growth was driven by a diversified basket, including engineering goods, petroleum products, electronics, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, textiles, gems and jewellery, rice and marine products, strengthening India's position in global value chains.

The US, the UAE, China, the Netherlands and the UK remained key export destinations. FIEO emphasised the need to further diversify markets and effectively leverage free trade agreements to expand India's global footprint.

According to Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ICRA Ltd, amidst a sharp year-on-year dip in oil imports following the West Asia crisis, India's merchandise trade deficit eased to \$20.7 billion in March 2026 from \$21.7 billion in the year-ago month, after having displayed a steep increase in January-February 2026.

Fuel, power costs push WPI to 3-month high of 3.9% in March

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Driven by escalating costs for fuel and power, wholesale inflation climbed to a three-month peak of 3.9 per cent in March, according to data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Wednesday.

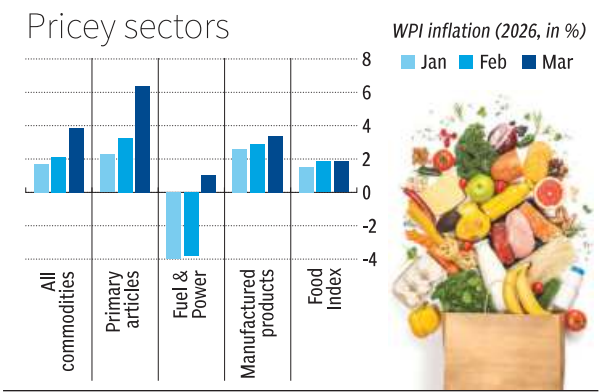
The Wholesale Price Index (WPI) data reflect a tightening squeeze on energy inputs, a trend that market analysts warn may not have peaked yet.

COST PRESSURE

Economists expect the upward trajectory to persist in the near term, potentially spilling over into retail inflation (CPI) as manufacturers and transporters pass higher operational costs on to consumers in the coming months.

"Positive rate of inflation in March is primarily due to increase in prices of crude petroleum and natural gas, other manufacturing, non-food articles, manufacture of basic metals and food articles, etc.," the Ministry said in a statement.

Further, data showed that WPI-based inflation rose for the fifth straight month in March as core inflation accelerated, amid softening of primary food items.



According to the data, inflation in the fuel and power basket spiked to 1.05 per cent in March, from a deflation of 3.78 per cent in February. Inflation in crude petroleum surged to 51.57 per cent during March, against a deflation of 1.29 per cent in the previous month. Manufactured products inflation rose to 3.39 per cent in March from 2.92 per cent in February.

"WPI inflation is a cleaner reflection of global commodity prices and captures the ongoing energy price shock better than CPI," Aastha Gudwani, India Chief Economist at Barclays, said. Of the 174 bps increase in headline WPI inflation, 93 bps was driven by crude petroleum and natural gas, followed by a 63-bps increase led by fuel and power WPI.

"As global energy prices stay elevated and eventually trickle to other commodity prices, we expect WPI inflation to rise further, going ahead," she said.

WAR IMPACT

According to Rajni Sinha, Chief Economist with CareEdge, the latest WPI data reflect a stronger impact of the West Asia crisis, rising by 1.7 percentage points compared to a modest 0.2 percentage points increase in retail inflation compared to February prints.

This divergence is driven by a sharp increase in bulk diesel and other commercial fuel prices, while retail petrol and diesel prices remained unchanged. Refineries raised bulk diesel prices by over 25 per cent in March amid the crisis.

Indian negotiators to resume talks on US trade deal from April 20

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi



Rajesh Agrawal, Commerce Secretary

An Indian delegation, led by Chief Negotiator Darpan Jain, will visit Washington from April 20 to 22 to resume talks on the India-US trade deal, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal announced on Wednesday.

The move comes as the government separately unveiled an aggressive 2026 roadmap for several major free trade agreements (FTAs), including the long-awaited deal with the UK, which is now expected to come into force by May.

The visit to Washington follows a 40-minute phone call between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump on Tuesday. Negotiators will focus on finalising the legal text of the Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) while addressing the impact of the new 10 per cent global import tariff introduced by the US in February.

According to officials, India and the US will work together to finalise timelines and next steps as part of the ongoing engagement. The fresh bout of negotiations comes amid evolving tariff rules in the US, with officials indicating that clarity on

Washington's trade stance remains crucial before any final deal. Earlier this year, India and the US agreed on an interim arrangement to reduce tariffs on Indian exports to 18 per cent.

According to data released by the Commerce Ministry, India's exports to the US stood at \$87.31 billion during April 2025-March 2026, registering only a marginal rise from \$86.51 billion in the previous financial year.

However, imports from the US increased sharply to \$52.90 billion from \$45.63 billion. Consequently, India's trade surplus with the US declined to \$34.41 billion in FY26, down from \$40.88 billion in FY25.

OTHER FTAs

Agarwal gave detail on the progress of various other FTAs "We expect the free trade agreement related to

Free trade agreements

	Progress	Expected timeline
India-US	Team going to US on April 20	Not indicated
India-UK	Finalised	Likely to be effective from May
India-Oman	Finalised	To be effective from June 1
India-New Zealand	Deal to be signed on April 27	Likely to be effective from October
India-EU	Likely to be signed by end CY2026	Likely to be effective from end FY27
India-EAEU	First round of negotiation done	Not indicated
India-Israel	First round of negotiation done	Not indicated
India-Australia CCEA	11 rounds of negotiations done	Not indicated
India-Canada CEPA	First round of negotiation done	Not indicated

Source: Commerce Ministry

the UK to come into operation in May sometime," the Commerce Secretary said.

Further, negotiations for the India-EU FTA are also set to conclude with the signing expected before the end of the current calendar year. The Ministry aims to bring the pact into force within the current financial year.

"FTA with the EU is likely to be signed before the end of this calendar year and try to get it into operation before the end of this financial year," Agarwal said.

India concluded negotiations for the India-New Zealand FTA, and domestic processes for signing and ratification will now take

place. Reviews for existing agreements continue, including the 11th round of negotiations for the India-Korea Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement. Negotiations continue with Australia for a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement and with Sri Lanka for an Economic and Technology Co-operation Agreement.

Agarwal highlighted other active discussions involving Peru, Chile, Israel, Canada and the Eurasian Economic Union. Terms of reference have been finalised for negotiations with the Philippines, Maldives and the Gulf Co-operation Council.

Govt enhances C3, C4 allocation for pharma, packaging chemical sectors to 1,000 tonnes/day

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) said on Wednesday that it will now make available 1,000 tonnes per day (TPD) of C3 (propane) and C4 (butanes/butenes) streams for critical sectors such as pharma, packaging and polymers.

The government introduced this scheme on April 1, under which refining companies, including petrochemical complexes have to make available certain minimum quantities of C3 and C4 streams for critical sectors under the Department of Pharmaceuticals, Department of Food & Public Distribution, and Department of Chemicals & Petro Chemicals.

The allocation is based on specific quantity and refinery source as determined by the Centre for High Technology (CHT). On April 8, the government allocated

The allocation of C3 (propane) and C4 (butanes) is based on specific quantity and refinery source as determined by the Centre for High Technology

800 TPD from the C3 and C4 streams to these critical sectors. This allocation has now been raised by 25 per cent to 1,000 TPD.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in MoPNG, said an inter-ministerial Joint Working Group (JWG) had been set up to ensure availability of petrochemical feedstock supply for the domestic market.

"Based on the requests received from the Department of Pharmaceuticals, Department of Chemicals & Petro Chemicals (DCPC), Department for Promotion of Industry and internal trade

(DPIIT), the provision for 1,000 TPD from LPG pool has been made for Pharma and Chemical sector companies. Since April 9, 2026, around 1,800 tonnes of propylene has been sold," she added.

DOMESTIC SUPPLY

Despite the ongoing geopolitical situation, the government has ensured 100 per cent supply to domestic LPG, domestic PNG and CNG (transport). Besides, the supply of 5-kg FTL cylinder to migrant labour has already been doubled, based on average daily supply on March 2 and 3.

LPG supply continues to be affected by the prevailing geopolitical situation. However, no dry-outs have been reported at LPG distributorships, Sharma said.

Total commercial LPG allocation has been increased to about 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, including 10 per cent piped natural gas (PNG) reform-linked allocation.

Since March 23, more than 14.6 lakh 5 kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders have been sold. Besides, PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) have organised more than 5,000 awareness camps for 5 kg FTL cylinders since April 3 wherein more than 57,800 units were sold.

A total of 1,34,226 tonnes of commercial LPG, which is equivalent to more than 70.64 lakh 19-kg LPG cylinders, has been sold since March 14. This includes more than 8,000 tonnes of auto LPG. The average auto LPG sale by PSU OMCs in April (till April 14) is around 282 TPD against the average of 177 TPD during February 2026.

Since March, about 4.5 lakh PNG connections have been gasified and another 5 lakh customers have registered for new connections.

As on date, more than 34,200 PNG consumers have surrendered their LPG connections via the MYPNGD.in website.

T.G.CO-OP OILSEEDS GROWERS' FEDERATION Ltd.,
9th Floor, Parisrama Bhavan, Basheerbagh, HYDERABAD - 500 004
TEL No: 040-23235501/02, E-mail: info@tgcofed.in
Notice No. P&P/Narmetta/Labour Contract/314/2026-27 Dt. 15.04.2026

E-Tender Notice

TGOLFED, Hyderabad invites e-tenders from eligible authorized and Reputed Service Providers for providing **Supply of Unskilled Labour, Material Handling Vehicles & General Services etc., for Unloading & Processing of FFB for a period of 2 Years** at Oil Palm Processing Unit at Narmetta Village, Nanganoor Mandal, Siddipet District, Telangana State.

NOTES: 1. Publish of E-Tender: 16.04.2026 at 3:00 PM & Last Date for uploading e-Tender was upto 23.04.2026 at 3:00PM. 2. All Details related to Tender will be available in e-Tender Website: <https://tender.telangana.gov.in> **Sd/- MANAGING DIRECTOR**
TGOLFED.

TATA
TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

CORRIGENDUM TO NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

Corrigendum-4 to the NIT dated 30th July 2025

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following package (Two Part Bidding) in **Transmission division, Mumbai.** Vide this Corrigendum-4, Pre-Qualification Requirement (PQR) stands revised for tender no.: CC26NP016.

- CC26NP016:** Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of 2x125MVA, 220/33kV, YNzn11, **Synthetic Ester Oil (SEO)** filled Power transformers at Worli RSS at Mumbai.

Detailed changes are outlined in the updated Notice Inviting Tender (NIT), available in the Tenders section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Interested bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter up to **1500 hrs of 22nd April 2026** for above tender. Also, all future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tender will be informed on Tender section on website. <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

TATA
TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Sahar Airport Road, Andheri East, Mumbai-400059
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following packages (Two Part Bidding) in Mumbai.

A) Miscellaneous Civil works for GIS Building at Kalwa Sub-station. **(Package Ref No: CC27SPV001).**

B) Supply of ACCC Hamburg Conductor (or any equivalent approved conductor) and Accessories for 400kV Dharavi - Vikhroli Project in Mumbai. **(Package Ref No: CC27FK001).**

A) Supply, Inspection & Testing of 33 kV HT cable at various transmission location in Mumbai. **(Package Ref No: CC27TP003)**

Interested & eligible bidders for above packages A, B & C to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter before **15:00 Hrs. Friday, 24th April 2026.**

For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website **(Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents)** only.

कोल इंडिया लिमिटेड
(एक महारन कंपनी)
(भारत सरकार का एक उद्यम)

कंपनी सचिवालय, सीएस 1 मिल, कोर-2, प्रेसिडेंस-04-एम्पायर
लॉट - ए एफ-III, एम्पन एरिया-1ए, न्यू टाउन, राजराहाट
कोलकाता-700156, दूरभाष: 033-2324-5555
ईमेल: complianceofficer.cil@coalindia.in
वेबसाइट: www.coalindia.in सीआईन - L23109WB1973GOI028844

NOTICE OF BOARD MEETING

Notice of Board meeting for consideration of Audited Financial Results for the 4th quarter and Financial Year ended 31st March, 2026 and recommendation of Final Dividend, if any

Pursuant to Regulation 29 & 33 of the SEBI (LoDR) Regulations 2015, notice is hereby given that a meeting of Board of Directors of the company will be held on **Monday, 27th April, 2026** inter-alia, to consider, approve and take on record the Audited Financial Results of the Company (Standalone & Consolidated) for the **4th quarter and Financial Year ended 31st March, 2026** after the results are reviewed by the Audit Committee of CIL Board.

Further, pursuant to Regulation 29 of the Listing Regulations 2015, notice is also given that Board of Directors of the company may also, inter alia, consider and recommend **Final Dividend** for FY 2025-26, if any. The payment of Final Dividend, if any, shall be subject to approval of shareholders in the ensuing AGM.

The Company has already closed its "Trading Window" under "CODE OF INTERNAL PROCEDURES AND CONDUCT FOR PREVENTION OF INSIDER TRADING IN SECURITIES OF COAL INDIA LIMITED" from 1st April, 2026 and it will re-open on 30th April, 2026. The said notice may be accessed on the company's website at www.coalindia.in under "Investor Center, Events & Announcements" and also on Stock Exchange websites www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com.

For Coal India Limited
Sd/-
B.P. Dubey
Place: Kolkata
Date: 13.04.2026
Executive Director (CS) & Compliance Officer

RAJAPALAYAM MILLS LIMITED
Regd. Office : Rajapalayam Mills Premises
P.A.C. Ramasamy Raja Salai, Post Box No.1, Rajapalayam - 626 117, Tamil Nadu.
CIN : L17111TN1936PLC002298 Telephone: 04563 - 235666, Fax: 04563 - 236520
Email: rajaco@ramcotex.com, Website: <http://www.rajapalayammills.co.in>

SPECIAL WINDOW FOR TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION OF PHYSICAL SHARES

Pursuant to SEBI circular SEBI/HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MRSD-PD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, shareholders are informed that, a special window is opened only for transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to 1st April, 2019.

The special window shall be open for a period of one year from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027.

Shareholders are requested to lodge transfer deed executed prior to April 01, 2019 along with original security certificate(s) and other documents as specified in the aforementioned SEBI circular with the Company latest by 4th February, 2027 at the below mentioned address:

The Company Secretary, Rajapalayam Mills Limited, Rajapalayam Mills Premises, P.A.C. Ramasamy Raja Salai, Post Box No.1, Rajapalayam - 626 117

PLACE: **RAJAPALAYAM** For **RAJAPALAYAM MILLS LIMITED**
DATE: **15-04-2026** **K. MAHESWARAN, SECRETARY**

KOVILPATTI LAKSHMI ROLLER FLOUR MILLS LIMITED
CIN: L15314TN1961PLC004674
Regd. Office & Flour Mill : 75/8, Benares Cape Road, Gangaikondan - 627352, Tirunelveli District, Tamil Nadu.
Phone : +91 462 248 6532, Mobile: +91 944 447 5445, Fax: +91 462 248 6132
Email: ho@klrf.in, Website: www.klrf.in

SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGE/MENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES

Pursuant to the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MRSD-PD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, we bring to your notice that another special window has been opened for a period of 1 year from February 05, 2026 till February 04, 2027 ("special window period") to facilitate transfer and dematerialization of physical shares which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2019. The special window shall be available for (i) re-lodgement of transfer requests which were submitted prior to April 01, 2019 and were rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/or otherwise and (ii) fresh lodgement of transfer requests which were not submitted prior to April 01, 2019, provided that the original share certificate is available.

The shares transferred during this special window period shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such shares shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period. Due process as prescribed under the said Circular shall be followed for such requests. Further, (i) cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee (to be settled through court/NCLT process), (ii) shares which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) and (iii) re-lodgement / fresh lodgement of transfer requests executed prior to April 01, 2019 where original share certificate is not available, will not be considered during this special window period.

Eligible investors are requested to avail this opportunity by submitting the transfer requests along with all the requisite documents as mentioned in SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MRSD-PD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 to MUFG Intime India Pvt Ltd (formerly "Link Intime India Private Limited"), the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (RTA) of the Company within the above stipulated time, whose details are as follows: Postal Address: Surya, 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore - 641 028, Tamil Nadu, India. Contact: +91 422 231 4792, 253 9835, 253 9836 Email: investor.helpdesk@in.mpmf.com

LAUNCH OF SECOND 100 DAY CAMPAIGN - 'SAKSHAM NIVESHAK'
FOR KYC AND OTHER RELATED UPDATES TO PREVENT TRANSFER OF UNPAID / UNCLAIMED DIVIDENDS TO IEPF

Pursuant to the Letter issued by the Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority, Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) and in continuation of the earlier campaign, the Company has launched the Second 100-Day campaign - "Saksham Niveshak" for a period from 1st April, 2026 to 9th July, 2026.

During this campaign, all the shareholders, who have not claimed their dividend for any financial years from 2020-21 to 2024-25 or who have not updated their KYC details / bank mandate / choice of nomination / contact information or having any issues related to unclaimed dividends and shares, may write to the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent (RTA) i.e. MUFG Intime India Private Limited (formerly "Link Intime India Private Limited"), "Surya, 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore - 641028, Tamil Nadu, India. Tel: +91 422 231 4792, 253 9835, 253 9836 Email: investor.helpdesk@in.mpmf.com

All the shareholders are requested to take advantage of this opportunity to update their KYC details, bank mandate, choice of nomination and contact information and are also requested to claim their dividend, which remains unclaimed, in order to prevent their dividend and shares from being transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority ("IEPFA"). The shareholders holding shares in demat form are requested to approach their respective Depository Participants for updating their KYC details / bank mandate / choice of nomination / contact information. The details of the above campaign and the details of unclaimed dividend are made available on the Company's website www.klrf.in.

UPDATE KYC AND CONVERT PHYSICAL SHARES INTO DEMAT MODE:

The shareholders who are holding shares in physical form are requested to update their KYC details / Bank details / choice of nomination / contact information by submitting the Investor Service Request Forms i.e. Form ISR-1, ISR-2, ISR-3, Form SH-13, as applicable and are also requested to convert their physical shares into dematerialized form.

By order of the Board
For Kovilpatti Lakshmi Roller Flour Mills Limited
S.Piramuthu
Date : 15.04.2026
Place : Gangaikondan
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
Membership No. FCS 9142

South intensifies delimitation pushback with poll-bound Tamil Nadu taking lead

UNITED FOR A CAUSE. TN Chief Minister Stalin escalates the issue with a call for a black flag protest across the State today

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

The proposed delimitation exercise has triggered a strong pushback from the southern States, led by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), with the protests unfolding bang in the middle of the on-going Assembly election campaign in the State.

Basing seat redistribution on population could reduce the parliamentary representation of the southern States that adhered to the nation's call for population control in the 1970s, argue Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana and Kerala, calling for a different, consensual way. Tamil Nadu has announced black-flag protests, and is also working to mobilise MPs nationwide.

BLACK FLAG PROTEST
Stalin on Wednesday escalated the issue with a call for a black-flag protest across Tamil Nadu on Thursday.

He also held a virtual meeting with DMK MPs to unite them to vote against the Delimitation Bill. Later, he convened a meeting with

district secretaries where, according to sources, he called on them to highlight the impact of the Bill on Tamil Nadu's representation to the masses as part of the election campaign.

"I appeal to all parties and MPs across India to unite to safeguard our democracy," said the CM in a social media post after the meetings. "Tomorrow, across Tamil Nadu, black flags will be hoisted on homes and public spaces in protest against delimitation," he added.

The strong pushback from the southern States comes amid concerns triggered by the draft Delimitation Bill that States which managed to stabilise their population between the 1970s and 2026 could lose their strength if the Lok Sabha seats are reapportioned based on the 2011 Census.

GOVT ASSURANCE
While the Central government has assured that the seats will be distributed across States in their existing proportion, this is not mentioned in the drafts of the Bills circulated by the government, say MPs.

P Wilson, Rajaia Sabha MP



STRONG OPPOSITION. Basing seat redistribution on population could reduce the parliamentary representation of States that adhered to the nation's call for population control, say southern States

from the DMK and senior advocate, pointed out that between 1971 and 2026 in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, population growth stood at 188 per cent and 170 per cent, whereas in Bihar, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh it was 314 per cent, 325 per cent and 290 per cent.

"Today, the voice of the southern States is set to be reduced in decision making and representation for adhering to population control;

we MPs will oppose the Bill," he told *businessline*.

'TO BE OPPOSED'
Other leaders and parties of Tamil Nadu, barring the NDA ally AIADMK, too, have strongly opposed the Delimitation Bill, while welcoming reservation for women.

Former Finance Minister and MP P Chidambaram said the Delimitation of Parliamentary Constituencies Bill must be "opposed unan-

imously and defeated". The current representation of the five southern States, which have stabilised their population, is 24.3 per cent. This will decrease to 20.7 per cent, he added.

Other southern States, too, have called for implementing women's reservation, but without any linkages to delimitation or the Census.

"There has to be an inclusive approach by taking into

account the sentiments of all those who would be impacted by the proposed delimitation exercise, especially the States. A consensual approach in this matter is absolutely essential," said Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan in a statement.

"The consequence of a *pro rata* model is not merely a statistical adjustment, but will result in a systemic shift in political power," said Revanth Reddy, Chief Minister of Telangana, urging consultations and democratic debates be used to identify other methods to do the redistribution, and voicing his support to Stalin's call for joint action.

Siddaramaiah, Chief Minister of Karnataka, said the current approach risks concentrating power in a few large States, "weakening Karnataka and the south and undermining the federal balance". However, Andhra Pradesh CM and NDA ally N Chandrababu Naidu, who wrote to political parties in the State, as well as to the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha MPs to seek their support for the Women's Reservation, was silent on his views on the Delimitation Bill.

QUICKLY.

We must chase away the Delhi team: Udhayanidhi

Ottapidaram/Kovilpatti: Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin insisted again on Wednesday that the upcoming Assembly elections are a battle between the Tamil Nadu team and the Delhi team, and that the southern State must "chase" Delhi away. "As our leader [MK Stalin] repeatedly says, this Assembly election is Delhi versus Tamil Nadu. We must win as the Tamil Nadu team. We must chase away the Delhi team," said Udhayanidhi.

Addressing a public meeting in the Ottapidaram constituency in Thoothukudi district for the April 23 polls, he urged the electorate to reject the BJP and its allies to protect the State's self-respect.

Campaigning for DMK candidate MC Ramajayam, Udhayanidhi highlighted the candidate's accessibility, stating that Ramajayam always remained among the people and focused on constituency issues such as water connectivity and infrastructure.

He contrasted this with the previous AIADMK administration, specifically criticising then CM Edappadi K Palaniswami for his handling of the Sterlite protests and Sathankulam custodial deaths. ¶¶



Will prioritise resolving Gorkha issue, says Shah

Kolkata: Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Wednesday that once the BJP assumes power in West Bengal, it will prioritise resolving the Gorkha issue in Darjeeling and will withdraw all cases registered against community leaders and workers for violent agitations in the past. Shah, who was unable to reach the upper reaches of Lebung in the Darjeeling hills due to unfavourable weather conditions, addressed the gathering through a recorded video message from Malda.

"I am deeply regretful of not being able to reach you today. But I promise you that I will meet you in person at the scheduled public meeting at Sukna in Kurseong on April 21, where I will discuss in detail the development roadmap for the hills and multiple announcements we have for the people of Darjeeling," he said.

"For now, I will say that once we form a government in Bengal, our priority would be to resolve the Gorkha issue as quickly as possible. We will withdraw all pending police cases against Gorkha leaders and workers after we come to power," he added. He said following the series of meetings he held so far while criss-crossing the State in the run-up to the polls, he had no doubt that the BJP would defeat the TMC in the upcoming elections. ¶¶



VOTER CONNECT



POLITICAL DRIVE. (from left) BJP State President Nainar Nagenthiran, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami during a roadshow in Nagercoil RAJESH N

Modi holds roadshow in Tamil Nadu

Press Trust of India
Nagercoil

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday held a well-attended roadshow in Kanniyakumari district, ahead of the April 23 Assembly polls in Tamil Nadu.

Joined by AIADMK Gen-

eral Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami, BJP State President Nainar Nagenthiran and his predecessor K Anamalai, Modi stood on top of a vehicle and waved at people who had lined up on either side of the road.

People showered flower petals on Modi, who embarked on a 1.5 km roadshow

from Veppamoodu junction to Vadasey in the town. Modi exuded confidence of the NDA emerging victorious in the April 23 Assembly elections. "The NDA is winning for sure, DMK is losing for sure, and we have to vote for better Tamil Nadu, *viksit* (developed) Tamil Nadu," he said.

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

High-stakes, three-cornered contest shaping up in Bengal's Baharampur

Mithun Dasgupta
Baharampur

"Is there any prohibition saying that a person who has been elected as an MP cannot contest the Assembly elections? There is no such prohibition. Even Mamata Banerjee, a seven-time MP, has been fighting elections for the Assembly," said veteran Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, who always plays with a straight bat.

A COMEBACK
Chowdhury, a five-time Congress MP and former leader of the party in the Lok Sabha, is all set to return to State politics after two-and-a-half decades.

Gearing up for a high-stakes battle, he is contesting from the Baharampur Assembly constituency in Murshidabad to recapture his former stronghold.

"In this Assembly poll, the Congress party is very much assertive. Our party is ahead in at least four districts in West Bengal. We are very much optimistic. The Congress will come out with good results," Chowdhury told *businessline*.

Causing a huge upset in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the heavyweight leader of the Grand Old

Party lost the minority-dominated Baharampur Lok Sabha constituency to Trinamool Congress' cricketer-turned-politician Yusuf Pathan. Making his electoral debut, the former all-rounder bowled Chowdhury out by winning the seat with a margin of more than 85,000 votes.

"Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee fielded the Muslim celebrity against me in order to make a dent in the Muslim electorate. The ruling party in the State also tried to engineer communal clashes in my constituency before the Lok Sabha elections to polarise voters in order to defeat me," Chowdhury pointed out.

WEAKENING GRIP
Political observers feel that apart from religious polarisation, Congress' weakening grip in Baharampur also led to the loss in 2024.

The party's continued weakness here remains a major headache for Chowdhury in this election, too.

The Baharampur constituency, among the 22 Assembly seats in the Muslim-dominated Murshidabad district, covers Baharampur municipality and five other gram panchayats. In the constituency, around 70 per cent voters are Hindu.

In a triangular contest,

Chowdhury will be taking on BJP's incumbent MLA Subrata Maitra and Trinamool Congress' Naru Gopal Mukherjee.

Maitra, who is seeking reelection, said the people of the State want a change in the government as they are "fed up with largescale corruption" being carried out by the Trinamool Congress.

"The BJP can ensure a stable and efficient government in the State," he said during an election rally.

"In this constituency, names of around 4,000 voters were deleted during the SIR of the electoral rolls," said Maitra.

Chowdhury has been demanding that the elections be postponed until all legitimate voters are included in the final voter list.

"Chowdhury is not a winning candidate. He lost this seat in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. His party lost the last Assembly elections in 2021. His vote bank has been shattered in five years. We are very optimistic this time as our candidate won the Lok Sabha polls two years ago," said TMC's Mukherjee.

Locals said that although Chowdhury is still a very popular leader here, the Congress' strength has diminished. For Chowdhury, it will be the toughest contest ever.

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Coimbatore North sees tight contest with BJP's Vanathi Srinivasan holding slight edge

T E Raja Simhan
Coimbatore

The Coimbatore (North) Assembly constituency is witnessing a keen battle between Vanathi Srinivasan of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Senthamil Selvan of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), with the emergence of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) adding an element of unpredictability.

The constituency is part of the politically significant Kongu belt, where the NDA, led by the AIADMK, is hoping for strong gains.

While the seasoned Srinivasan, who won from Coimbatore (South) in 2021 appears to have a marginal edge owing to her familiarity and a strong support base, particularly among women, the ground reality suggests a contest that's far

from one-sided. The entry and growing influence of TVK, led by actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay, has injected a new dimension, with young voters drawn to the party seeking change.

This is likely to contribute to a split in what were once consolidated, strong vote banks.

In Sai Baba Colony, for instance, a group of autorickshaw drivers who have traditionally supported the DMK, now find themselves divided between the DMK, the AIADMK and the TVK. Personal influences are also shaping decisions.

SUPPORT FOR TVK
One auto driver Ganesan said he was backing the TVK largely due to his son's insistence, reflecting the sway younger voters hold within families.

However, despite the buzz around the TVK,



DIFFERENT APPROACH. (from left) DMK candidate Senthamil Selvan campaigning in the Coimbatore North constituency; Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta campaigning for Vanathi Srinivasan in the constituency BUJOY GHOSH

ground level campaigning was hardly seen on Wednesday. Among other voters,

opinions vary. Leela, who works at a tea shop, believes the BJP's Srinivasan is the



stronger candidate, while others prefer to keep their choices private. A 78-year-

old resident, Thenmozhi declined to reveal her preference, even to her family, un-

derscoring the guarded nature of voter sentiment. Her neighbour Rajathi, however, said her long-standing admiration for leaders such as MG Ramachandran and J Jayalalitha would guide her vote in favour of the BJP, though she felt nostalgic about the AIADMK's two leaves symbol.

WOMEN'S SAFETY
Key issues in the constituency mirror broader concerns across Tamil Nadu. Residents point to women's safety and the increasing availability of drugs and alcohol as factors that have dented the DMK's image.

DMK candidate Selvan, an engineering graduate who previously worked in the IT sector, has been countering this narrative by highlighting the party's development initiatives.

He cited projects such as Semmozhi Poonga, the GD

Naidu flyover and a proposed cricket stadium, and promised to support MSMEs in the densely populated residential-cum-industrial area of Ganapathy through the creation of a dedicated industrial park.

ECONOMIC ISSUES
Srinivasan, who has been hospitalised in recent days, has focused her campaign on economic issues, criticising hikes in property tax and electricity tariffs, which she said had adversely affected local industries.

In her absence, her son Adarsh has been actively campaigning on her behalf.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta's presence on Wednesday gave a boost to Srinivasan's election campaign.

After visiting Srinivasan at the hospital, Gupta undertook a road show, urging voters to vote for the BJP.

SIP with caution

MF investors hold out in falling market, but a tad confused

India’s stock indices plunged 10 per cent in the past month in the wake of the Iran war. This has been the first prolonged correction in stocks since the Covid crash. Therefore, mutual fund (MF) flows were being closely watched to gauge if the post-Covid cohort of retail investors who jumped into stock markets in large numbers were panicking.

Latest data from the Association of Mutual Funds of India (AMFI) suggest the opposite. Far from panicking and pulling out money, investors have raised their net inflows into equity funds to ₹40,450 crore in March from ₹25,977 crore in February 2026, a 56 per cent jump. Flows through the Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) route hit a new record in March, bringing in ₹32,087 crore and up 7.5 per cent from the previous month. All this is good news. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have been engaged in a relentless barrage of selling in Indian stocks, prompted by valuation worries and risk aversion. But domestic investors have to put a floor to the correction and offer companies continued access to capital. While the big picture suggests that domestic investors as a class are displaying a high degree of maturity, a deeper dive into the data suggests that not all investors are on the same page. For one, while macro risks today argue for sticking with larger companies and being valuation-conscious, the pattern of MF flows suggest continued high risk-taking by some investors.

In March, mid- and small-cap funds received many times the inflows (₹12,326 crore) that large-cap funds (₹2,997 crore) and value funds (₹2,155 crore) did. Rather than simply urging investors to ‘buy when there’s blood on the street’, the MF industry and its intermediaries ought to steer investors towards the right categories of funds at the appropriate times. Two, while aggregate SIP flows rose in March, SIP stoppages spiked to 53.38 lakh accounts from 49.87 lakh. The number of new SIPs initiated also fell from 65.7 lakh to 52.8 lakh. This does not make a material dent in the 9.71 crore active SIP accounts or in the aggregate MF inflows. But it does show that while seasoned investors are probably topping up their SIPs, newer investors are spooked into stopping them. As SIPs are designed mainly to average one’s cost in falling markets, some investors clearly do not understand how SIPs work. It is up to the fund industry, which sits on large coffers of ‘investor awareness’ money, to educate investors.

It is also moot if investors are maintaining a desirable allocation to safer asset classes such as debt funds. The number of debt fund folios managed by the industry at 82.8 lakh is at a fraction of the equity accounts which total 18.27 crore (as of end-March 2026). This is partly due to the extremely unfriendly taxation of debt fund gains at slab rates. However, the MF industry also needs to make serious efforts to popularise debt so that retail investors handle market falls with equanimity.



Is TCS harassment case tip of the iceberg?

It raises questions about workplace safety in an industry which employs the maximum number of urban women employees



POINT BLANK.



Corporate India has recently been rocked by news of sexual harassment of women employees at TCS. The way female employees were left defenceless over an extended period, despite the legal mandate to companies to provide protection to women at their workplaces, raises doubts about the seriousness with which India Inc deals with the POSH (Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal)) Act, 2013.

The complaints span four years from July 2022 to March 2026 and involve complaints from eight women employees of TCS’ Nashik office involving sexual assault, harassment, injury to religious sentiment and religious coercion. Complaints to the Human Resources department did not stop these offences and the accused were let off with mere verbal warnings. The Nagpur police has now stepped in and arrested seven individuals with one person absconding; a special investigation team has also been formed to investigate the case.

N Chandrasekaran, the Chairman of Tata group, has said that the issue is ‘gravely concerning and anguishing’, while suspending all the eight accused. Interestingly, he has also said that “any necessary process improvements or corrective measures will be promptly implemented and strictly enforced.” This statement appears to be signalling that there were gaps in the processes followed by the company in dealing with POSH complaints.

If the country’s bellwether IT company with market capitalisation of ₹9.25 lakh crore, employing over six lakh people, is found wanting in ensuring a safe workplace for women, it is quite possible that other companies are also

POSH related disclosures

	TCS		Infosys		Wipro		HCLTech	
	FY24	FY25	FY24	FY25	FY24	FY25	FY24	FY25
Total complaints under POSH Act	110	125	64	43	93	125	75	44
POSH complaints as % of female employees	0.05	0.06	0.06	0.04	0.14	0.18	0.14	0.09
POSH complaints upheld	66	78	61	33	64	115	56	30

Source: Company annual reports

taking it easy in this regard and many women are suffering silently, especially in the IT sector.

THE LEGAL MANDATE The POSH Act, which came into force after the Supreme Court ruling in *Vishaka* case, seeks to protect women from any act of sexual harassment at workplace. It mandates that every company should have an internal complaints committee made of three employees and one external member. When companies have branches in different cities where women employees work, there should be an internal committee at all such branches.

Besides having a committee in place, companies are also expected to display the names and contact details of all internal committee members prominently on notice boards so that employees are aware about the persons they can reach out to in case of transgressions. Regular awareness programmes among employees regarding the POSH rules is another mandate.

THE GAPS IN TCS CASE While all the details of the case are yet to be revealed, the information being

IT companies need to assure all their women employees that they are in a safe workplace and their grievances will be heeded seriously

Natural farming should become mainstream policy

A Green Transition Fund can serve as the anchor — pooling resources, directing them towards verified outcomes

PVS Suryakumar
GV Ramanjaneyulu

Natural farming and agroecological practices are no longer fringe ideas. They are being successfully practised across India — albeit unevenly and often without systemic support. There are strong proponents of natural farming, but also persistent sceptics who invoke food security as a reason for caution. Yet some of them now quietly and grudgingly acknowledge that the Green Revolution (GR) has left behind a trail of ecological stress and public health concerns.

The policy direction too is beginning to shift. The Prime Minister has repeatedly underscored that practising natural farming is akin to serving Mother Earth, and the approval of the National Mission on Natural Farming (NMNF) in November 2024, with an outlay of ₹2,481 crore, signals strong intent. But intent alone does not deliver transformation. The NMNF’s provision of ₹8,000 per farmer over two years for one acre is a start, but it is unrealistic to expect farmers to shift from entrenched GR practices on the basis of such a one-off payment.

The GR was underpinned by a comprehensive public policy framework — backed by sustained investment in irrigation, seeds, extension, credit, markets, and the public distribution system. Natural farming, by contrast,

cannot be expected to scale on a token incentive in the absence of comparable systemic support. If it is to move from promising examples to widespread practice, the real question is how that transition will be financed. And public policy must state this clearly — and act on it. Transition support is not another subsidy — it is bridge finance for a public good. Farmers shifting away from input-intensive GR practices incur immediate costs: learning new practices, rebuilding soil biology, managing yield uncertainty, and reorganising labour and preparing botanical inputs.

SHARING THE COSTS These costs are upfront, while the benefits — healthier soils, lower input dependence, and climate resilience — accrue over time. A rational policy cannot expect farmers to finance this ecological correction on their own. If society benefits from the ecosystem services they generate, it must also share the cost. Transition support should invest in capacity building, field-level support, local resource systems, and market linkages, with incentives tied to measurable ecological outcomes. Priority must go to small and marginal farmers, tenant farmers, and women farmers, who bear the highest transition risk.

First, the State must anchor the transition. Public finance should support what are clearly public goods — extension, training, community institutions, demonstration farms,



TRANSITION FINANCE. The burden cannot rest on farmers’ DEEPAK KR

monitoring systems, and certification where necessary. These constitute the infrastructure of adoption. If ecological farming is a public priority, the institutions that enable it must be publicly funded. The burden cannot rest on farmers, nor on a narrow segment of consumers paying premiums. While the benefits of ecosystem services — healthier soils, safer water, and reduced chemical exposure — accrue to society at large, the costs of transition cannot be left to those least able to bear them. Without this, natural farming will not move beyond announcements.

Second, transition finance must be blended. Government alone cannot carry the entire load, nor will public budgets suffice. Corporate social responsibility, philanthropic capital, climate finance, ecosystem-service incentives, and credit-linked instruments must be aligned towards a common outcome. A catalytic Green

be true. While false complaints are quite common, the low proportion of proven complaints could deter women from coming forward to lodge complaints.

TCS employed 6.3 lakh employees in 2024-25, of which 35.3 per cent were women. Around 2.2 lakh women work in the organisation. The number of complaints filed account for just 0.06 per cent of this universe. While it could point towards a safe and happy working environment, it could also point towards lack of awareness about POSH rules among female employees.

RED FLAGS FOR IT INDUSTRY While Nasscom has issued a statement saying that this incident should not be taken as indicative of ‘systemic weakness across the sector’, it does raise questions about the safety of women employees in the IT sector.

With the sector employing more than 20 lakh women and accounting for over one-third of the workforce in the sector, it is especially important that all IT companies ensure that they have proper channels for complaining and active internal committees in all cities to address these complaints. Regular awareness workshops are also required to let women know about the presence of these support systems.

It is typically seen that the women employees in the IT companies are employed at the lower and mid-levels, with a large proportion of them aged under 40 years. These women are quite vulnerable and may not want to lodge sexual harassment complaints due to fear of losing their jobs. Some may fear physical harm to themselves or families and so desist from complaining. IT companies need to assure all their women employees that they are in a safe workplace and their grievances will be heeded seriously.

The Ministry of Child and Family Welfare must carry out an audit of the POSH compliance in all companies in general and IT companies in particular. If women’s participation in workforce must be improved, improving POSH compliance and adoption is an exigency.

Transition Fund can serve as the anchor — pooling resources, directing them towards verified outcomes, and bringing coherence to what is otherwise a fragmented landscape of schemes and pilots. This framework must also recognise programme delivery costs — farmer facilitation, local institutions, and certification — as core public investments. Emerging instruments such as carbon markets and payments for ecosystem services can further strengthen the transition over time.

Third, transition support must be anchored in incentive reform. As long as policy continues to reward input-intensive GR agriculture, financial support will only soften — not resolve — the underlying contradiction. Procurement and price signals must shift to support crops grown through natural farming — millets, pulses, oilseeds — and other locally suited cropping systems.

Without this alignment, transition will remain partial and reversible. India already has the ingredients — farmer institutions, public finance, CSR, climate funds, and emerging ecosystem-service markets. What is missing is coherence and commitment.

Natural farming cannot remain a boutique intervention; it must be treated as a national development strategy.

Suryakumar is former Deputy Managing Director, NABARD, and Ramanjaneyulu is Executive Director, Centre for Sustainable Agriculture. Views are personal

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Margin pressure

This refers to ‘Banks hike spread on repo-linked loans’ (April 15). While repo-linked lending promises transparent and faster transmission, an absolute and uniform reduction in lending rates is difficult in practice. Well-rated, high-value borrowers often negotiate the finest rates irrespective of market direction, and banks are compelled to concede due to competitive pressures. This creates an asymmetry: when rates soften, banks must reduce pricing for such borrowers; but when rates

harden, upward revision becomes difficult for fear of losing business. At the same time, deposit mobilisation does not keep pace without higher rates, putting pressure on margins. In this backdrop, increasing spreads is less a distortion and more a survival response. The broader concern is that sustained margin pressure may push banks towards fee-based income, sometimes leading to mis-selling of third-party products. **J Kumar** Srirangam, Trichy

BRICS should step up

This refers to ‘Iran war, a boon for the BRICS’ (April 15). The common perception is that the West Asia affairs are not getting the attention they deserve from those in charge of governance and diplomacy at the highest level. The suggestion that BRICS can play a more proactive role in the West Asia affairs has to be welcomed. If international organisations like the UN have largely been silent, regional organisations like the European Union and BRICS need to rise to the

occasion and coordinate with nations in the affected regions and help out the people affected by the chaos. In the present situation, India and China have to play a more proactive role, going beyond protecting self-interest. **MG Warrior** Mumbai

Improving cyber security

With reference to ‘Cyber insecurity’ (April 15), the measures suggested by the banking regulator in controlling digital frauds are vital,

since many Indians with their poor financial and digital literacy are by default becoming first-time users of digital interfaces and are susceptible to digital frauds committed by vested interests, misusing the technological inadequacies. The unpredictability centred around recovery of defrauded funds pose a big challenge leading to loss of trust in the system. Creation of more dedicated cybercrime cells would improve public confidence. **Sitaram Popuri** Bengaluru

Aiding piped gas push

Stainless steel pipes are safe and viable for PNG

Amir Ullah Khan
Yajna Prakash

As the US-Israel-Iran hostilities entered their second month and Iran’s retaliatory strikes effectively choked the Strait of Hormuz, the ripple effects began to surface across global energy supply chains — testing the resilience of countries heavily dependent on imported fuels.

India was among the first to feel the strain. LPG cylinders began disappearing from shelves, depots, and doorsteps, disrupting everyday life.

The government responded by issuing the Natural Gas and Petroleum Products Distribution Order 2026, by directing the oil refineries and gas processing plants to increase LPG production by 25 per cent and introduced a 25-day inter-booking period to curb hoarding. It has also put on hold commercial supply of natural gas to hotels, restaurants, and other industries, while leaving out hospitals and educational institutions.

The government also issued an order stating that LPG supply may be discontinued within three months for households that have access to PNG but fail to switch, while acknowledging that over 6,000 PNG consumers had voluntarily surrendered their LPG connections, helping redirect supply to remote households without pipeline connectivity.

However, things have improved recently, with domestic refinery production ramped up by 40 per cent, bringing daily LPG output to 50 TMT — more than 60 per cent of India’s total daily requirement of approximately 80 TMT. The shift to PNG from LPG is understandable. Not only is there greater domestic production of PNG than LPG, but it is also much easier to transport through pipelines rather than through trucks and ships as is the case with LPG.

A POWERFUL ACCELERATOR
The crisis has functioned as a powerful accelerator, with more than 2.9 lakh PNG connections — covering both domestic and commercial users — have been provided across the country in March alone. Yet, as of March 2026, India has only around 1.6 crore domestic PNG connections, with the government aiming to reach 5 crore PNG connections by 2030.

However, one major impediment behind PNG’s slow take-off among many top malls,



WAR IMPACT. LPG shortage
SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

hotels and luxury housing, despite lower costs and less vulnerability in such crises are issues of safety and aesthetics. Yellow-coloured galvanised iron pipes sticking out of the buildings are not just an eyesore for the building’s facade, but also a safety risk — gas leakage — given the high number of joints in these pipes and exposed to such extreme weather conditions.

There is, however, a faster, smarter alternative to rigid GI piping — Corrugated Stainless-Steel Tubing, or CSST — whose flexibility, light weight, and ease of installation could do what years of policy persuasion has failed to: make PNG connections genuinely quick, affordable, and accessible enough to drive real behavioural change at scale.

A battle-hardened pipe that flexes with ground shifts, resists hydrogen embrittlement, and seals joints tighter than GI ever could, and can be routed through walls, adds to the overall safety.

Moreover, since it installs easily without threading or welding at every turn and bends, it delivers significant savings on time and labour cost during its installation. Its flexibility allows workers to pull it like an electrical wire thereby routing it through walls, attics, crawl spaces, and even retrofitted into existing homes more easily without any safety issues.

However, like every crisis, this too presents an opportunity, a great opportunity for luxury apartment builders, restaurants, malls, hospitals, and industrial kitchens to shift to a PNG infrastructure. And, for the corrugated stainless steel tubing (CSST) industry, with its flexible, lightweight architecture, engineered for rapid, scalable deployment in complex-built environments, it could prove to be a defining moment.

Khani is Economist, and Member, Telangana Public Service Commission; Prakash is Partner at Acclime India



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Stocks are the least over-priced asset in India

INVESTMENT CALL. But they are still over priced. Indian investors can look at selectively investing abroad due to rupee volatility



GURBACHAN SINGH

Though the stock prices have fallen by about 15 per cent in India this year, the price-earnings ratio (P/E) is still at about 20, and the growth of earnings is not high. The valuations are, compared to emerging market economies, still about 40 per cent higher.

This is even when we have left out the mid- and small-cap stocks, where the valuations are even higher in India.

However, all this is not the complete story. High valuations are not confined to just stocks. Assets in general in India, are and have been for a long time, over-priced in India.

Stocks are, as we will see, actually the least over-priced asset class in India at this juncture. In other words, expected long-term returns on other financial or real assets in the country are effectively even lower. This larger picture usually does not get much attention in the usual narrative.

It is true that a comparison between different kinds of assets is problematic, and investors differ from each other. However, some observations are made here, which can be generally useful. Let us consider the various other asset classes one by one before we come to the stock market.

BANK FDS

Let us begin with the fixed deposits (FDs) in banks. The interest rate on an FD for five years or more in a leading bank is, for example, 6 per cent per annum. At 4 per cent long-term target

inflation, the real return rate is 2 per cent.

When inflation jumps up, now and then, due to some shock, and the nominal long-term interest rates do not rise adequately, then the real return on FDs can be lower, and even negative for some year(s). So, bank FDs are not always very safe in real terms.

Other debt instruments like government bonds, corporate bonds, debt mutual funds, schemes run by alternate investment funds (AIFs), public provident fund (PPF), etc. can be better than bank FDs. However, some concerns apply here as well. For many investors, there is also a relative tax disadvantage for debt instruments including bank FDs.

This is not to say that these should not have some place in the asset portfolio. What about gold? The international price of gold fell by about 15 per cent in a few weeks. And, the real annualised return is 1.1 per cent over 175 years from 1836 to 2011 (Barro and Mishra 2016). It is true that in recent years the central banks have been buying a good amount of gold. There is also more private demand. All this may suggest a sustained high return on gold in future.

However, one cannot be sure. It is, going forward, apparently viable and profitable to mine out more gold in the

Compared with bank FDs, gold and real estate, stocks are relatively cheaper. But they are also ruled by sentiment and fundamentals, which can vary, leading to volatility in stock prices

long term, given the market price and the significantly lower total mining cost. Also, there is some new competition for an asset like gold.

Bitcoin is credibly limited in quantity, possibly more than gold is. So, it is not clear if the gold price will continue to rise anywhere near the way it has done in the last two years. And, compared to gold, the story of silver is really no better at this point of time.

REAL ESTATE

Let us next come to real estate in India. There is, of course, high demand for homes. And, real estate as an asset continues to be very useful for anyone with black money in India. However, beyond these considerations, real estate is not an easy asset for just investment purposes for an ordinary investor. The past returns may seem good on the surface.

However, the inflation-adjusted, risk-adjusted, effort-adjusted and stress-adjusted returns on real estate are questionable for very many investors. There is more to the story. At present, there are many obstacles for real estate development on the scale needed in India. However, there can be, going forward, a big reform, and a major liberalisation in policy.

When this happens, it can bring down future returns on real estate. Relative to physical real estate, it can be better for many to invest in real estate investment trusts (REITs). However, considering the volatility and the expected returns, it is not clear why, at this juncture, stocks should not get significantly more attention.

In the stock market, there has been a time correction from September 2024. And, there has been a serious price correction as well this year. The corrections have been for the high

valuations and also for the effect of the war in the Middle East. Stocks are no longer very expensive.

In fact, relative to other assets in India, they are now arguably the least over-priced. This is assuming that India remains distant politically; it is distant geographically anyway. It is true that the public and the economy in India are being significantly impacted by the war in the Middle East.

THE STOCK MARKET STORY

But the story of the stock market is different. The stock prices represent the returns in all the future years to come. And, as history and theory suggest, the effect on the fundamental values of stocks can be limited. It is also true that regardless of the war, sentiment and fundamentals can vary, and stock prices can fluctuate considerably. This can discourage investors.

However, long-term investors can invest in a seemingly boring financial product like the balanced advantage fund, which invests in equity and debt dynamically on its own.

A corollary is that the much-hyped index funds are not always suitable. In conclusion, stocks are arguably the least over-priced asset class at present in India. But the fact remains that these are over-priced! So, there is a need to selectively invest outside of India to an extent and in a phased manner.

This is, *a fortiori*, the case as there can be an additional long-term benefit due to the real appreciation of some foreign currencies. These arguments are about expected returns on stocks abroad at this juncture. So, it is not just about the benefit due to international diversification.

The writer is an independent economist. He has taught at Ashoka University, ISI (Delhi) and JNU

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 16. 2006

‘Growth in cell user base may be exaggerated’

The phenomenal growth in mobile subscriber base being reported by the operators every month may not be entirely true. According to a new study done by the US-based research and analyst firm Yankee Group, the addition of new cellular subscribers in the country may be exaggerated by about 10-15 per cent.

Maruti, MSAIL merger to ease product rollouts

The announcement of the pro posed merger of Maruti Suzuki Automobile India (MSAIL) with Maruti Udyog has eased concerns about the roadmap for future product rollouts by the latter. MSAIL’s car plant, which is to be operational by the end of the year, would have an initial capacity of 100,000 units and 250,000 units by 2008. T

Gangavaram port project: Malaysian co picks up 20 pc

Intergrax Berhad of Malaysia has joined the Rs 1,700-crore Gangavaram Port project as ‘technical partner’, picking up 20 per cent equity in the consortium led by Mr D.V.S. Raju. The Malaysian company re placed Dubai Port International that used to provide technical services.

Trump threatens to fire Powell if he doesn’t exit Fed

Powell’s term expires in May, says he’ll serve ‘pro tempore’ if his successor is not confirmed by then

Josh Wingrove
Skylar Woodhouse

US President Donald Trump said he would fire Jerome Powell if the Fed chair does not step down “in time,” adding that he would not drop the Justice Department investigation into the central bank leader.

“I’ll have to fire him, OK, if he’s not leaving on time. I’ve held back firing him. I’ve wanted to fire him, but I hate to be controversial,” Trump said in an interview with Fox Business.

“I want to be uncontroversial. But he will be fired,” he said in the interview that aired Wednesday.

Powell’s stint as the leader of the central bank expires in May, but his term on Board of Governors does not end until 2028. Trump did not clarify the timeline for which he would seek to remove Powell.

TEMPORARY DESIGNATION

Powell has said that if his successor is not confirmed before his term as chair ends in May, he would serve as chair *pro tempore*.

The Fed has conferred that temporary designation in the past on a board member to lead the institution when the chair role was vacant.

Trump allies have hoped that Powell would also resign his board seat when his time leading the central bank comes to a close this spring.

Powell, however, has said he has “no intention” of resigning from the board until the Trump administration’s investigation by the Department of Justice into a building renovation project is “well and truly over.”

But in the interview, Trump suggested he had no plan to end the investigation.

“Whether it’s incompetence, corruption or both, I think you have to



UNDER PRESSURE. Jerome Powell REUTERS

find out. I really do; I think you have to find out,” he said.

POWELL’S SUCCESSOR

The investigation could also delay getting Powell’s designated successor, Kevin Warsh, confirmed.

North Carolina Senator Thom Tillis, a key swing voter on the banking committee, has praised Warsh but insists he will block confirmation until the DOJ probe is resolved, calling the investigation a threat to the Fed’s independence.

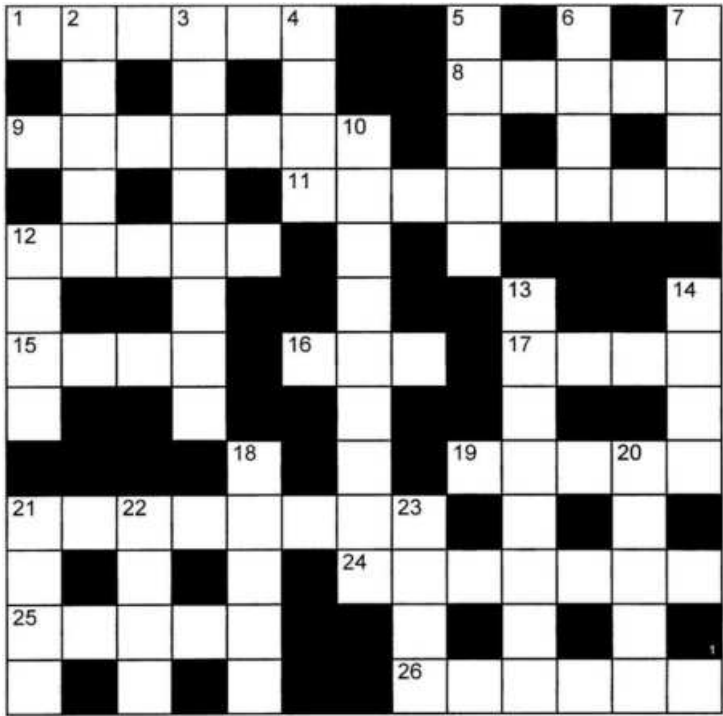
That sets up a potential showdown between Trump and Powell in the coming weeks that would likely morph into a legal battle testing the limits of Trump’s power.

The President has also sought to oust Fed Governor Lisa Cook, a case which has gone to the Supreme Court and has yet to be decided.

Despite Tillis’ stance, the Senate Banking Committee has scheduled an April 21 confirmation hearing for Warsh.

US prosecutors made a surprise visit to the Fed’s offices in Washington Tuesday, but were denied entry to the site, Bloomberg

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2659



EASY

ACROSS

1. Rigorous, austere (6)
8. Awaken (5)
9. Make one feel low (7)
11. Over-exerted (8)
12. Take on as one's own (5)
15. A flatfish (4)
16. Took nourishment (3)
17. By mouth (4)
19. Timepiece (5)
21. Swift traveller (8)
24. Footballer (7)
25. Narrow middle part (5)
26. Food for horses (6)

DOWN

2. Movement of fashion (5)
3. Burst in (8)
4. Throw lightly (4)
5. Use the feet (5)
6. Change direction (4)
7. Curve (4)
10. Street cry after theft (4,5)
12. In addition (4)
13. Went after (8)
14. Exploding shell fragments (4)
18. Devotion (5)
20. Work at stone, wood (5)
21. Robe (4)
22. Produced (eggs) (4)
23. Top of building (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

1. Almost all the cards taken in the street are austere (6)
8. Make one get up, or return to employment (5)
9. Push down the lever to make one blue (7)
11. Used too much effort, the water being taken out (8)
12. After some fuss, pupil teacher will take on a child (5)
15. But it is not the only fish in the sea (4)
16. Dined on starters of anchovies, taramasalata and escargots (3)
17. Some of the poor always have to take a viva voce (4)
19. Design on sock may give one the time of day (5)
21. I've the right to follow bird with him on his travels (8)
24. Send on his mail for the man on the field (7)
25. Bit in the middle one will not make good use of, one hears (5)
26. Fred is upset about a party that returned the food (6)

DOWN

2. Movement fashion takes will incline to include the right (5)
3. Being put out in a form of rider, it broke in (8)
4. Drunkard turning up with direction to spin a coin (4)
5. Part of a step can be measured on a tyre (5)
6. Lathe-operator will produce an act in the variety theatre (4)
7. It goes round the end of the kerb, one may conclude (4)
10. Arresting cry, if the post is disrupted (4,5)
12. In addition, is thus to come after a pound (4)
13. Was able to understand it if one tailed along (8)
14. Jackal frequently turned up holding barrage met by fliers (4)
18. It is a shame the East is involved with religiosity (5)
20. If one wishes to create sculpture, tackle the Sunday joint (5)
21. Something to wear shown the green light when he leaves (4)
22. Boy took one in, having produced clutch (4)
23. Some cover, where the householder is concerned (4)

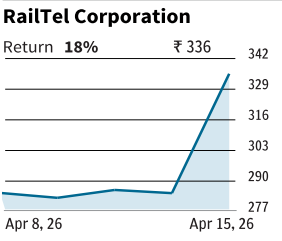
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2658

ACROSS 1. Concealment 8. Overtake 9. Gala 10. Drown 13. Sari 16. Stay 17. Omen 18. Apes 20. Adept 24. Cape 25. Evidence 26. Number-plate

DOWN 2. Oxen 3. Cater 4. Askew 5. Edges 6. Morris-dance 7. Marionettes 11. Opera 12. Nurse 14. Army 15. Bare 19. Steam 21. Diver 22. Pedal 23. Knit

QUICKLY.

RailTel jumps 18% after bagging orders from RVNL



Mumbai: Shares of RailTel Corporation of India climbed sharply on Wednesday after the company disclosed multiple work orders, including two large tunnel communication contracts. The stock ended at ₹336.73 on the NSE, up ₹52.35 or 18.41 per cent. It bagged two back-to-back orders from RVNL. Package 1 covers supply, installation, testing and commissioning of integrated tunnel communication systems valued around ₹309.28 crore, and Package 2 covers tunnelling four stations for approximately ₹255.27 crore. The company, in a separate disclosure, mentioned the cancellation of a previously-announced ₹17.13-crore IT infrastructure order from Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti. **OUR BUREAU**

SBI MF unveils 2 Constant Maturity Index Funds

Bengaluru: SBI Mutual Fund has launched 2 Constant Maturity Index Funds — SBI Crisil-IBX Financial Services 3-6 Months Debt Index Fund and SBI Crisil-IBX Financial Services 9-12 Months Debt Index Fund. The new fund offers that opened on April 15 for both schemes will close on April 20. A constant maturity index designed to track the performance of commercial papers, certificates of deposit and corporate bond securities maturing within three-six months and 9-12 months from the date of inclusion in the index. **OUR BUREAU**

Dalal Street sees best day in weeks on Gulf news

MARKETS SOAR. BSE Sensex surges 1,263 points to 78,111, while the Nifty 50 settles 388 points higher at 24,231 on all-round buying

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

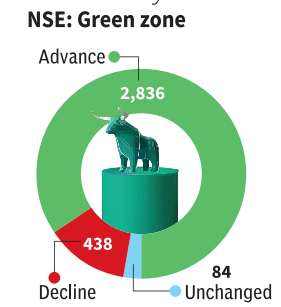
The markets surged on Wednesday, delivering their strongest session in weeks as geopolitical optimism, falling crude oil prices and buoyant global cues triggered broad-based buying that left virtually no sector untouched.

The BSE Sensex closed at 78,111.24, gaining 1,263.67 points, while the Nifty 50 settled at 24,231.30, up 388.65 points — its highest close since March 10.

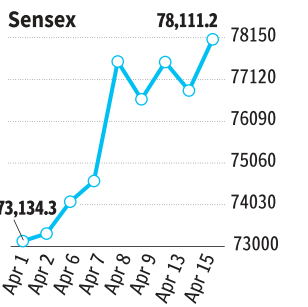
From its recent swing low of 22,182, the Nifty has clawed back over 2,100 points in just eight trading sessions. Volumes on NSE's cash market rose 12 per cent from the previous session, underlining the conviction behind the move.

The single-biggest cata-

Bull's day out



Nifty Gainers	Close (₹)	% change
Indigo	4,638.00	4.76
Eternal	246.67	4.42
PowerGrid	312.45	4.03
Max Healthcare	990.05	4.03
HDFC Life	640.45	3.45



lyst was US President Donald Trump signalling that Washington and Tehran may be heading back to the negotiating table, with talks potentially resuming in Pakistan within days, describing the conflict as “close to being over.”

Midcap and Smallcap indices outperformed benchmarks, rising over 2 per cent each. Of the Nifty 500 uni-

verse, 446 stocks closed green against just 53 in the red.

CRUDE, VIX CRASH

According to provisional data, FPIs turned buyers to the tune of ₹666.15 crore while domestic institutions, surprisingly, took a contra stand by offloading shares worth ₹568.98 crore.

Brent crude fell to around

\$93-\$95 a barrel for a second straight session, holding comfortably below the psychologically-critical \$100-mark, direct relief for India's import bill and inflation outlook.

The fear gauge agreed. India VIX tumbled nearly 9 per cent to 18.67.

Ajit Mishra of Religare Broking noted, “Atability in the rupee and a decline in

volatility ... further contributed to the positive undertone, while optimism around the ongoing earnings season kept sentiment buoyant.”

GAINERS, LOSERS

IT, Consumer Durables, Realty and Capital Goods led sectoral gains, with the Capital Market index the standout, rallying over 3.5 per cent.

Auto staged a sharp recovery after being the prior session's laggard. Pharma was the lone holdout, as investors rotated out of defensives into cyclical.

IndiGo, Power Grid and Eternal topped the Nifty gainers list, while Dr Reddy's, Bharti Airtel and ICICI Bank ended in the red.

Pranay Aggarwal, CEO, Stoxkart, cautioned, “Uncertainty around foreign institutional investor flows persists, while potential

earnings downgrades could limit valuation expansion.”

GROWTH LEVERS

On the macro side, March CPI came in at 3.4 per cent, marginally above February's 3.2 per cent.

The headline was benign, but a sharp jump in electricity and fuel inflation signals early energy price pass-through from the West Asia conflict — keeping the FY27 inflation trajectory skewed to the upside.

Looking ahead, Thursday's earnings slate — Wipro, HDFC Life, HDFC AMC, Crisil and Angel One among others — will drive stock-specific action.

As Siddhartha Khemka of Motilal Oswal put it, “Indian equities are expected to sustain their upward bias as long as the peace talk narrative holds and crude stays in check.”

Groww hits 52-week high as BofA initiates ‘Buy’ call

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Billionbrains Garage Ventures, the parent company of stock broking platform Groww, surged to a 52-week high of ₹212.90 on Wednesday after Bank of America (BofA) Securities initiated coverage on the stock with a ‘Buy’ rating and a target price of ₹235.

BofA Securities expects Groww to deliver revenue growth of 30 per cent CAGR between FY26 and FY28, citing the company's positioning to benefit from India's retail investing tailwinds.

The brokerage projected

EBITDA margins and PAT margins expanding to 67 per cent and 52 per cent respectively by FY28, driven by operating leverage.

VALUATION

It valued the company at 39x its FY28 estimated price-to-earnings multiple. Near-term risks flagged include weak capital market performance and the upcoming expiry of the six-month lock-in period for pre-IPO shareholders.

Groww shares gained over 33 per cent in the past month and are up about 95 per cent from their IPO issue price of ₹100. It listed on the NSE on November 12, 2025.

NSE active clients fall 7 per cent to 4.57 crore in FY26

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The retail trading momentum hit a speed bump in FY26, with active clients on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) falling 7 per cent year on year to 4.57 crore from 4.92 crore — a record decline of nearly 35 lakh accounts and the first annual contraction in three years.

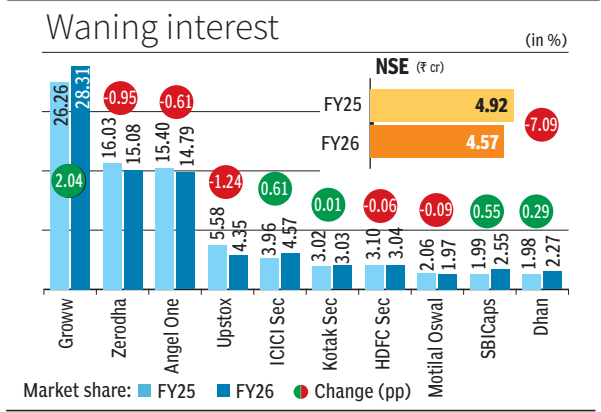
The drop was heavily concentrated among the top discount brokers. Zerodha alone accounted for 29 per cent of the decline, shedding 9.95 lakh active investors. Angel One lost 8.15 lakh accounts (23 per cent) and Upstox (shed 7.6 lakh (22 per cent), meaning the three platforms

together drove over 70 per cent of the industry-wide contraction. Other brokerages including Mirae Asset Capital Markets, HDFC Securities and Sharekhan each reported losses in the range of 1.3-2.72 lakh accounts.

Groww was a notable exception. The market leader grew its share from 26.26 per cent to 28.31 per cent, and dominated Q4 additions — capturing 116 per cent of net industry additions in January, 75 per cent in February and 80 per cent in March, effectively compensating for losses elsewhere.

MARKET EXPANSION

Among traditional brokers, ICICI Securities expanded its market share from 3.96 per



cent to 4.57 per cent, SBI Securities rose from 1.99 per cent to 2.55 per cent, and Dhan climbed to 2.27 per cent. Paytm Money was the biggest net gainer in absolute

terms, adding 2.12 lakh active investors during the year, followed by SBI Cap Securities with 1.82 lakh.

Analysts attribute the slowdown to multiple head-

SEBI makes it easier for firms to cut IPO size as Iran war hits sentiment

Reuters
Mumbai

SEBI will allow companies to cut the size of IPOs by as much as 50 per cent without filing additional onerous paperwork, as the Iran war has made it hard to follow through with initial plans, according to an e-mail seen by Reuters.

Current rules stipulate that initial public offering (IPO) documents need to be refiled if the planned fundraising amount increases or decreases by 20 per cent or more.

ON A FAST TRACK

Firms will now only have to submit their revised offer size to SEBI for approval and these reviews will be fast-tracked, the regulator said in an e-mail sent to the Association of Investment



Bankers of India. The relief will apply to issuers planning to raise fresh funds before September 30 and will only be granted if there is no change in the main objective of the issue, the email said.

PLAN FUND-RAISES

“By end of September, the West Asia crisis will either be resolved or companies will be in a position to better plan their fund raises,” said a source with direct knowledge of the matter, who was not authorised to speak to the media and declined to be

identified. SEBI did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

It said in the email that rules were being eased as market participants were facing issues in mobilising resources and accessing capital markets due to tensions in the West Asia.

RECENT TWEAK

Last week, SEBI allowed companies whose deadlines for an IPO are due to lapse between April 1 and September 30 to have until September 30 to complete them.

It also said companies would not be penalised if they could not meet the requirement of having 25 per cent of their stock held by public shareholders.

As of April 2, SEBI had given its approval for 143 companies to raise a combined ₹1.745 lakh crore.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

ICICI PRUDENTIAL AMC (BUY)

Target: ₹3,850
CMP: ₹3,215.75
ICICI Prudential AMC's (IPRU) operating revenue grew 20 per cent year on year (flat quarter on quarter) to ₹1,520 crore (in line) in Q4FY26. Yields came in at 55 bp vs. 57.7 bp in Q4QY25 and 56.3 bp in Q3FY26. For FY26, revenue grew 23 per cent to ₹5,760 crore. Total opex at ₹360 crore was down 5 per cent. EBITDA came in at ₹1,160 crore (in line), up 30 per cent YoY/2 per cent QoQ. Margins stood at 76.5 per cent vs. 70.5 per cent in Q4FY25 and 75.3 per cent in Q3FY26. For FY26, EBITDA came in at ₹4,290 crore, up 29 per cent YoY.
PAT stood at ₹760 crore (8 per cent miss due to negative other income), up 10 per cent YoY but down 17 per cent QoQ. For FY26, PAT came in at about ₹3,300 crore, up 24 per cent YoY.
Overall gross yield stood at 52 bp, with net yield at 48.3 bp as of March 2026; the management indicated new TER regulations (effective April 2026) may impact gross yields by 3-4 bp (under negotiation). Net yields for AIF/PMS improved to 0.98 per cent in Q4FY26 from 0.91 per cent in Q3FY26, driven by product mix. We have maintained our earnings estimates for FY26, FY27 and FY28, factoring in relatively lower equity AUM growth, which is expected to be offset by incremental income and AUM inflows from SIF and ICICI Venture investments. Over FY26-28E, we project AUM/revenue/PAT CAGRs of 17 per cent/15 per cent/16 per cent. We maintain our Buy rating on the stock, with a target price of ₹3,850.

Antique Research

ACME SOLAR (BUY)

Target: ₹363
CMP: ₹285.25
ACME Solar's operational capacity is set for a step-change growing from 2,540 MW in FY25 to 6,270 MW by FY28E, as firm and dispatchable renewable energy (FDRE) projects progressively commission. We expect a revenue/EBITDA/PAT CAGR of 71 per cent/70 per cent/77 per cent respectively as the mix shift toward higher-tariff, higher CUF FDRE driving EBITDA per MW from ₹64 lakh to ₹1.34 crore by FY30E with FDRE contributing 57 per cent of consolidated EBITDA by FY28E rising to 70 per cent by FY30E. ACME holds the largest FDRE contracted pipeline at 4,031 MW, with 2,980 MW already converted into firm PPAs with government-backed counterparties. Project-level equity IRRs are compelling with 25 per cent for Assured Peak, 20 per cent for Peak-Only, and 16 per cent for RTC. These returns have structural upside from post-commissioning debt refinancing and battery cost deflation, every \$10/kWh decline in BESS costs adds 150-300 bps to equity IRRs. We value ACME at 10.5x FY28E EV/EBITDA, arriving at a target price of ₹363. This multiple is backed by a DCF valuation and translates into an implied 3x FY28E P/BV, which appropriately reflects the sharp improvement in return profile (FY28E at 23 per cent ROE) as high-CUF, high-tariff FDRE assets scale. At current levels, the stock trades at a discount to renewable peers despite superior 70 per cent/77 per cent EBITDA/PAT CAGR and the largest FDRE pipeline in India. We initiate coverage with a BUY rating.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Siemens (₹3,576.90): BUY

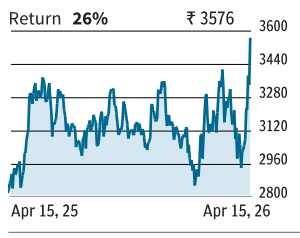
Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Siemens. The stock surged about 7 per cent on Wednesday breaking above the key resistance level of ₹3,400. This also confirms the bullish breakout of the prolonged sideways range that has been in place for almost one year.

The region between ₹3,400 and ₹3,370 will act as a good support. It can limit the downside if there is any intermediate dip.

Siemens share price can rise to ₹3,800 and even ₹4,000 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy Siemens shares at ₹3,577. Accumulate on dips at ₹3,460. Keep the stop-loss at ₹3,330

Siemens



initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹3,610 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹3,660.
Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹3,720 and ₹3,840 when the share price touches ₹3,790 and ₹3,890 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹3,960.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24225 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
24160	24050	24320	24500	Go long on a break above 24320. Keep the stop-loss at 24290	
₹810 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
804	798	814	820	Go long on dips at 806 and 806 with a stop-loss at 802	
₹1305 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1290	1280	1320	1335	Immediate outlook is unclear. Avoid trading the stock	
₹302 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
300	298	304	307	Go long only above 304. Stop-loss can be kept at 303	
₹287 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
285	282	291	295	Take fresh longs above 291. Keep the stop-loss at 290	
₹1342 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1335	1320	1355	1375	Go long only above 1355. Stop-loss can be kept at 1345	
₹1071 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1060	1045	1090	1120	Go long on dips at 1065. Keep the stop-loss at 1055	
₹2553 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2520	2475	2580	2605	Go short on a turnaround from 2580 with a stop-loss at 2590	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 388.65 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
HDFC Bank	809.90	50.75	16.10	11.16	
Reliance Ind	1344.10	42.73	18.60	8.17	
L&T	4076.30	31.25	29.55	4.31	
Infosys	1295.30	21.80	18.90	4.12	
TCS	2554.90	18.34	18.69	2.35	
Kotak Bank	382.40	16.86	20.23	2.53	
Eternal Ltd	246.67	16.42	1030.50	1.60	
PowerGrid Corp	312.45	11.96	18.72	1.27	
Hindalco	1011.45	10.48	14.14	1.32	
IndiGo	4638.00	10.40	55.85	0.94	
Sun Pharma	1696.10	10.26	37.17	1.62	
Bajaj Finance	913.15	8.29	31.01	2.20	
Adani Ports	1511.80	7.48	27.87	1.00	
Titan	4522.20	7.46	84.24	1.68	
UltraTech Cement	11785.00	7.31	45.32	1.26	
State Bank	1071.50	7.20	11.43	4.00	
ITC	302.05	7.15	18.38	2.62	
M&M	3256.50	7.08	23.96	2.62	
Asian Paints	2423.10	6.97	59.44	0.99	
Tech Mahindra	1483.80	6.70	31.67	0.85	
NTPC	392.60	6.57	15.33	1.68	
Max Healthcare	990.05	6.23	67.89	0.66	
Maruti Suzuki	1339.60	6.19	27.98	1.32	
Hind Unilever	2157.60	5.89	50.42	1.72	
Tata Motors PV	357.90	5.67	48.67	0.67	
SBI Life	1971.00	5.55	79.74	0.80	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1020.95	5.15	21.00	1.29	
HCL Tech	1451.30	5.04	23.91	1.38	
HDFC Life	540.45	5.01	73.11	0.62	
Trent Ltd.	8978.20	4.98	87.31	0.79	
Bharat Elec	447.65	4.77	54.88	1.44	
NestleIndia	1256.60	4.77	74.29	0.81	
Bajaj Finserv	1825.80	4.72	15.22	0.95	
Wipro	209.75	4.23	16.50	0.54	
Tata Steel	208.72	4.20	28.56	1.55	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	242.66	3.95	36.07	0.72	
JSW Steel	1218.60	2.96	38.37	1.03	
Apollo Hosp	7642.00	2.82	58.89	0.71	
Grasim Ind	2741.40	2.36	19.70	0.94	
Eicher Motors	7128.00	2.34	36.50	0.88	
Cipla	1227.00	1.95	21.86	0.62	
Ais Bank	1355.50	1.82	15.95	3.50	
Bajaj Auto	9865.00	1.18	31.04	0.98	
Adani Enter	2144.40	0.87	17.51	0.50	
TataConsumerProduct	1094.20	0.55	73.58	0.64	
Coal India	435.80	0.35	9.03	0.89	
ONGC	287.60	0.44	8.05	1.01	
Dr Reddys Lab	1217.80	-2.41	18.40	0.67	
ICICI Bank	1348.10	-4.68	17.05	8.68	
Bharti Airtel	1855.70	-10.18	30.52	5.13	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 1,446.05 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Bpcl	310.45	100.12	5.47	2.59	
HindustanAeronautics	4239.20	74.61	31.87	3.31	
Hdfc Amc	2663.70	67.63	39.71	2.23	
Vedanta	7166.05	64.75	18.08	5.36	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	748.00	61.78	106.18	2.11	
Tata Power	421.85	58.13	26.92	2.91	
Siemens	3576.10	58.03	80.32	1.30	
Varun Beverages .	445.55	57.76	49.21	2.51	
SamvardhoseInternatl	123.55	55.47	35.83	2.25	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1550.60	52.47	71.25	2.73	
Power Finance	444.75	46.04	4.40	2.67	
Indian Oilcorp	145.22	43.67	5.56	2.23	
Limintired	4628.70	42.46	29.05	1.77	
Divis Lab	6177.50	38.56	66.15	3.23	
Dif	587.45	34.50	32.84	1.55	
Tata Motors Cv	435.20	31.86	97.32	3.74	
Macrotech Developers .	860.50	31.63	25.69	1.02	
Tvs Motor Comp	3783.30	29.97	58.86	3.66	
Godrej Consumer	1085.50	29.07	60.98	1.80	
Indian Hotels Co .	646.40	28.38	42.51	2.34	
Canara Bank	141.71	27.98	6.98	1.97	
Sree Cement	24965.00	25.11	50.15	1.37	
Solar Industries	1488.00	24.82	88.23	1.49	
Bajaj Holdings	10058.50	24.50	12.49	1.97	
Adani Power	183.43	24.29	31.91	3.12	
Punjab & Bank	128.87	22.87	7.27	1.61	
Ambuja Cements	454.00	22.38	22.80	1.14	
Union Bank	188.71	21.98	7.61	1.50	
Britania Ind	580.50	21.97	20.78	1.04	
Hindusind Ind	5654.50	21.78	56.36	2.74	
Rural Elec	352.65	19.92	5.39	1.81	
Capillary	116.12	18.35	11.93	1.93	
Bank Of Baroda	279.07	17.54	7.35	2.13	
United Spirits	1252.40	17.43	52.96	1.52	
Siemens Energy India .	291.80	17.25	87.98	1.06	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	101.72	15.90	1.97	0.84	
Hyundai Motor India .	1781.40	14.91	25.00	1.05	
Hero Cycles	129.31	12.93	12.93	1.00	
Bosch	37080.00	11.39	96.69	1.32	
Muthoot Fin	309.81	10.91	16.69	1.59	
AvenueSuper	1047.30	10.52	101.03	1.21	
AdaniGreenenergy	1096.05	10.03	97.27	1.51	
ZydusLifeSciences	936.05	9.64	18.14	0.96	
Harman Dock	9.35	9.35	42.55	0.65	
Abd India	6873.00	6.59	86.36	1.48	
Communis India	5003.40	4.58	61.87	2.78	
Jindal Steel	1221.30	2.93	61.80	1.86	
Pidlindit	1329.50	2.63	58.47	1.70	
Adani Energy Solutions .	1171.15	-4.06	59.02	1.67	
Trent Pharma	4159.30	-6.41	61.96	1.75	

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

HDB Financial Services
Q4 profit up 41%

New Delhi: HDB Financial Services on Wednesday reported 41.4 per cent y-o-y growth in profit after tax (PAT) at ₹751 crore for Q4FY26. For FY26, the company reported 17 per cent growth in PAT at ₹2,544 crore. Gross loan book stood at over ₹1.18 lakh crore as on March 31, 2026 against about ₹1.07 lakh crore a year ago, a growth of 10.9 per cent. Net interest income was up 21.6 per cent at ₹2,399 crore in the quarter ended March 31, 2026. PTI

Muthoot Finance to enter insurance market

New Delhi: Muthoot Finance on Wednesday sought shareholders' approval for foraying into the business of insurance distribution (in both life and general insurance sectors). In a postal ballot notice, Muthoot Finance sought shareholders' nod for making changes to the Memorandum of Association of the company and aligning with the Companies Act, 2013, the company said in a regulatory filing. PTI

‘US-Iran talks could resume soon’

RIPPLE EFFECT. Global stocks nudge higher on US President Trump’s optimism

Reuters
Dubai/Washington

US President Donald Trump said talks with Iran to end the war could resume soon and result in a deal, telling the world to watch out for an “amazing two days”, while US forces imposing a blockade turned back vessels leaving Iranian ports.

With the prospect of the US and Iranian officials returning to Pakistan for more talks, Vice-President JD Vance, who led negotiations that ended on Sunday with no break-through, said he felt positive about where things stood.

“I think you’re going to be watching an amazing two days ahead,” Trump told ABC News reporter Jonathan Karl, adding he did not think it would be necessary to extend a two-week ceasefire that ends on April 21.

“It could end either way, but I think a deal is preferable because then they can rebuild,” Trump said, according to a post by Karl on X. “They really do have a dif-



ON TENTERHOOKS. US President Donald Trump told the world to watch out for an “amazing two days” REUTERS

ferent regime now. No matter what, we took out the radicals.”

GLOBAL STOCKS UP Officials from Pakistan, Iran and several Gulf States also said negotiating teams from the US and Iran could return to Islamabad later this week.

Talks last weekend broke down without an agreement to end the war, which erupted on February 28 with the US-Israeli strikes on Iran, triggering Iranian attacks on its Gulf neighbours and re-igniting a parallel conflict between Israel and Iran-

backed Hezbollah in Lebanon. Trump’s optimism helped nudge global stocks higher with fresh record-highs in view. Benchmark oil prices — having fallen on Tuesday and in early Wednesday trade — climbed to around \$96 per barrel, after the US military said its blockade had completely halted trade going into and out of Iran by sea.

More vessels were being turned back under the US blockade, including a US-sanctioned, Chinese-owned tanker Rich Starry that was making its way back to the

Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday after exiting the Persian Gulf. Earlier, the US military said it had intercepted eight Iran-linked oil tankers since the start of the blockade on Monday, according to *The Wall Street Journal*. A US destroyer stopped two oil tankers attempting to leave the Iranian port of Chabahar on the Gulf of Oman on Tuesday, a US official said.

Iran’s semi-official Mehr news agency reported that Iran would use alternative ports to those on its southern coastline to bypass the US blockade and expand import capacity across different regions of the country.

Trump, speaking to *New York Post* on Tuesday, said his negotiators were likely to be back, thanks largely to the “great job” Pakistan’s Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir was doing to moderate the talks.

Later on Tuesday, at an event in Georgia, Vice-President Vance said Trump wanted to make a “grand bargain” with Iran, but there was a lot of mistrust between the two countries.

Time to focus on ‘desi’ fleet creation

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

The recent geopolitical conflict has highlighted another vulnerability beyond energy dependence — the near absence of a domestic tanker fleet. Reliance on foreign shipping companies has led to high freight costs, supply chain disruptions, and limited powers in negotiating shipping rates and terms.

ANALYSIS.

To address this gap, the country has begun efforts to strengthen its tanker fleet, with initiatives such as public-private partnerships.

According to Gopal Krishna, former Secretary of the Ministry of Shipping (Ports, Shipping, and Waterways), Government of India, who played a crucial role in the development of the Indian maritime sector, earlier in the government and now as the guiding force behind the Bharat Pravah initiative, “there is a need to look at two critical aspects when trying to understand the issue. One is ship-building and the other is flagging. What is needed is primary focus on ship-building.”

“Even if it is an Indian flag vessel, that is, a vessel registered in the country, it is only 10 per cent of the story. The ship may still be built outside India. Only when the ship is built in India and then flagged in India do we get the full advantage of the logistics and economic value chain. What we have to keep in mind is that ship, unlike other industries, is a moving asset and very international in nature,” he said.

The focus, for India, should therefore be ship-building followed by flagging, he said adding that as far as flagging is concerned “right now the entire industry is dominated by four-five countries.”

In shipping, vessels are broadly classified into two types: Dry cargo vessels and liquid cargo vessels



India’s efforts to build its tanker fleet are underway, with initiatives such as PPPs

(tankers). “What we are seeing today is need for liquid cargo vessels or tankers mainly for importing crude oil, petroleum products and LPG. To build such tankers is a very costly business, and the product is very price-sensitive, so there are lot of things that need to be considered,” he said.

HYBRID MODEL

Jayaraman Krishnan, partner at S. Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP, said, “India needs to adopt a hybrid model as ship-building requires deep pockets.”

“Unlike China and Korea, India, has not been able to create its own fleet strength mainly because, as a policy, over the years, the government has ended up making Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) a sole monopoly,” he said, adding there has been “no” competition.

SCI MONOPOLY

In fact, the mandate to oil and gas companies is that they can go for other shipping companies only when SCI refuses them, he explained adding “SCI fleet renewable policies were never on time with requirement. Everyone knows that India is heavily dependent on imports to meet its fossil fuel requirements. The decision makers felt that chartering vessels to bring fuel was easier. Besides, Indian shipyards were incapable of building Very Large Crude Carriers.”

Since fuel is very price

sensitive, particularly LPG, it was found that chartering vessel to bring fuel was easier.

VESSELS’ INSURANCE

Another challenge is insurance for these vessels, he said adding “it is a known fact that success of any insurance industry is re-insurance. Here, we never looked at creating a separate vertical for the purpose.”

The key departments and Ministries are constantly working towards addressing packaging, logistics and shipping challenges amid West Asia conflict.

The Merchant Shipping Act, 2025, has been enacted to modernise the legal framework, improve ease of doing business, and encourage Indian flagging of ships. Indian-flagged vessels are promoted through the Right of First Refusal (RoFR), simplified ship registration, and other regulatory reforms. Shipping vessels, of more than a certain size, have been classified as infrastructure assets to enable easier access to finance.

Reports reveal that South Korean and Chinese shipyards are supported by massive state-backed refund guarantees and low-cost financing.

Indian builders face much higher interest rates and have historically lacked a dedicated maritime financing institution, though the newly created Maritime Development Fund aims to fix this. China has gone for government-built ships, whereas South Korea has a hybrid model.

India’s Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 aims to increase the country’s ship-building capacity and competitiveness, and strategic partnerships with countries like South Korea can play a crucial role in achieving this goal.

Gopal Krishna said he agrees that a South Korea-type hybrid model can work for India in increasing its shipbuilding capacity and competitiveness.

NBFCs can now open branches sans prior approval

Our Bureau
Mumbai



The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has decided to allow non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), including gold loan companies and microfinance institutions, to open branches without its prior approval in a bid to provide them operational flexibility.

This move is to facilitate ease of doing business while ensuring necessary regulatory compliance, going by the RBI (Non-Banking Financial Companies – Branch Authorisation) Amendment Direc-

tions, 2026. This also comes in the backdrop of NBFCs’ gross advances increasing to 25 per cent of scheduled commercial banks’ gross advances as at March-end 2025 against 23.64 per cent as at March-end 2024.

“An NBFC is generally permitted to open branches without having the need to obtain prior approval from RBI, unless otherwise specifically restricted,” per the amendment to the November 2025 RBI (Non-Banking Financial Companies – Branch Authorisation) Directions, 2026.

As per the November 2025 RBI (Non-Banking Financial Companies – Branch Authorisation) Directions, 2025, NBFCs have to notify the RBI of their intention to open the proposed branch.

On receipt of such advice, the RBI may, on being satisfied that in the public in-

terest or in the interest of the concerned NBFC or for any other relevant reasons to be recorded, reject the proposal and communicate the same to the NBFC. If no advice of rejection of the proposal is communicated by the RBI within 30 days from the receipt of such advice, the NBFC may proceed with its proposal.

GOLD LOAN COMPANIES

Gold loan companies will have a sigh of relief due to the freedom to open branches. The November 25 Directions shackled their branch expansion plans. As per the Directions, a NBFC -

Port and dock workers’ federations call for agitation against new labour codes

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi



WORKERS’ DEMANDS. The federation opposed the outsourcing of core port activities and criticised the move to limit contract workers’ wages to minimum wage levels

The National Coordination Committee of Port and Dock Workers Federation has demanded that port managements should not implement the new labour codes, and warned of intensified agitation if workers’ concerns remain unaddressed.

At a recent meeting in Mumbai, the committee directed workers to chalk out protest plans. The federation opposed the outsourcing of core port activities and criticised the move to limit contract workers’ wages to minimum wage levels, arguing that port operations demand multiple skills and higher qualifications.

They maintained that contract workers in the sector deserve wages on par with regular workers, considering the nature and complexity of

their duties. The committee expressed concern over reports that some port managements are attempting to implement provisions in the labour codes that could enable hire-and-fire policies, termination of existing contract workers and reduction in wages.

CD Nandakumar, President of the Water Transport Workers Federation of India, said port and dock workers across major ports have de-

cided to intensify their agitation against what they termed as “anti-worker” labour reforms.

KEY PROVISIONS

The committee noted that several key provisions of the existing statutory settlement are yet to be implemented, even as it is set to expire in December 2026.

Trade unions pointed out that they had deferred a proposed strike on February 12,

following a request from the Indian Ports Association, which had assured discussions to address workers’ demands.

However, the unions alleged that the management has failed to honour its commitments. In response, the committee has decided to launch a 45-day campaign across major ports, protesting against various anti-labour initiatives. The campaign will culminate in a nationwide protest by port workers on May 21.

The committee raised concerns over the escalating war situation in West Asia and its impact on the sector, particularly seafarers stranded in the Strait of Hormuz. The unions urged the Centre, the International Transport Workers’ Federation and the International Maritime Organization to take steps to ensure the safe evacuation of seafarers.

US Ambassador meets Oil Minister Puri over expanding energy purchases

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi



Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri with US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor

US Ambassador Sergio Gor met Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Wednesday to discuss on expanding access to American energy and ensuring energy security.

“Great meeting with Minister @HardeepSPuri to advance the US-India energy partnership. We discussed strengthening energy security and unlocking new opportunities for accelerating growth. Expanding access to reliable American energy will further deepen our economic ties and support long-term energy security and diversity for both nations,” Gor said on X.

India has been upping its energy purchases from the

US since President Donald Trump assumed office last year. Higher energy imports from Washington will help narrow India’s trade deficit with the latter and fit into New Delhi’s broader strategy of diversifying energy supply chains.

PRODUCTIVE TALK

Puri on X said, “Happy to receive @USAmbIndia H.E. Amb Sergio Gor in my office

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Gold slips with eyes on US-Iran developments



Gold drifted lower on Wednesday after hitting a one-month peak as investors assessed the latest signals on the US-Iran situation and what they could mean for the interest rate outlook. Spot gold was down 0.6 per cent at \$4,809.15 per ounce as of 1247 GMT. US gold futures fell 0.4 per cent to \$4,831.60. REUTERS

Crude oil stable amid Strait of Hormuz curbs

London: Crude oil prices were broadly stable as shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remained constrained, countering expectations of US-Iran talks. Brent crude futures were up 49 cents at \$95.28 a barrel at 1315 GMT. US West Texas Intermediate crude was up 9 cents at \$91.37. REUTERS

Copper at 6-week high on hopes of peace talks



London: Copper prices hit six-week highs as the prospect of another round of talks between the US and Iran to end the war boosted sentiment. Benchmark copper on the London Metal Exchange touched \$13,392.5 a tonne. Prices of aluminium are trading at 4-year highs at \$3,565, zinc rose 1.2 per cent to \$3,382 and lead added 0.8 per cent to \$1,951.5. REUTERS

Offers for urea import jump 84% in two months due to war impact

BID FRENZY. Lowest price for the West Coast was offered by Millenium Commodity at \$935/t for just 56,000 tonnes

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Indian Potash Ltd, one of the three canalising agencies for government urea imports, has received supply offers totalling nearly 6 million tonnes (mt) against the 2.5 mt sought in its April 4 tender. However, the steep cost and freight (CFR) quotes — around \$935 per tonne for the West Coast and \$959 per tonne for the East Coast — have sent shock waves through the global market. The government is expected to decide on the purchase quantity and pricing by April 23.

PRICES JUMP The spike marks a sharp escalation from the previous tender floated by Rashtriya Chemicals and Fertilizers Ltd in mid-February, which



SUPPLY RUSH. The govt is expected to take a call on purchase quantity and pricing by April 23

saw offers at \$508 per tonne (West Coast) and \$512 (East Coast) for March-end delivery. Delays in shipments were later condoned due to

the ongoing war. “If we compare the lowest bids, prices have risen about 84 per cent in just two months,” said a trader who

participated in the latest tender. “While the West Asia conflict is a factor, India’s decision to seek a large volume in one go has also signalled

urgency to the market ahead of the June sowing season. Buying at these levels could push global prices even higher.”

WIDE SPREAD IN BIDS Sources said the lowest West Coast offer, at \$935 a tonne, came from Millenium Commodity for just 56,000 tonnes. Aditya Birla Global Trading quoted \$941.70 for 1.35 mt, close to the 1.5 mt requirement. The highest bid for the West Coast was \$1,136 a tonne for 1,00,000 tonnes from Comet Trading. For the East Coast, the lowest price of \$959 was offered by Chasemax for 1,00,000 tonnes against the 1 mt requirement. Aditya Birla Global Trading quoted \$966 for up to 6,50,000 tonnes, while Comet Trading again placed the highest bid at \$1,136 per tonne for 50,000 tonnes.

Fertilizer supply crunch tightens global farm economics

Gayathri G
Chennai

Global fertilizer markets are under severe strain following geopolitical disruptions, raising concerns over farm economics, crop output and food price stability, according to a new report by RaboResearch. In its latest assessment released on April 8, the research arm, a unit of Rabobank, said the sector ended the first quarter of 2026 with tight availability, sharply higher prices and elevated volatility across key nutrients. Escalating tensions in

West Asia and the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz have removed a substantial volume of fertilizers and critical inputs from global trade, triggering a supply shock that cannot be quickly replaced. Fertilizer affordability has deteriorated sharply, with nitrogen and phosphate prices rising much faster than agricultural commodities, compressing farm margins. “Our fertilizer affordability index has moved decisively into negative territory and is expected to remain constrained throughout 2026,” said Bruno Fonseca, Senior Analyst – Farm Inputs, RaboResearch. He warned that this

could lead to “demand destruction” as farmers cut application rates, delay purchases or shift crop choices. **SUBSIDY CONCERNS** For India, the impact is particularly significant given its heavy dependence on imports, especially for phosphates and potash. Higher global prices could increase subsidy burdens for the government and strain farm profitability, even as policymakers attempt to shield farmers from price shocks. Nitrogen markets are expected to see one of the steepest demand declines in 2026, while phosphate markets remain under pressure.

Potash is relatively balanced but may face indirect demand weakness. Protectionist trade measures are also limiting alternative sourcing, reinforcing supply tightness. Even if geopolitical tensions ease, normalisation is expected to be slow, with elevated prices likely to persist into 2027. **WHEAT UNDER THREAT** Despite these pressures, global agricultural supply remains comfortable in the near term. Most fertilizer inputs for the Northern Hemisphere’s 2026 crop were secured before the conflict. Large harvests are expected in key producing regions,

including record soybean output in Brazil and ample corn and soybean plantings in the US. However, there are concerns about the 2026 wheat crop due to dry conditions in Canada, the US and parts of Argentina, heat stress in India, and mixed conditions in the Black Sea region. Additionally, higher fertilizer costs have Australian farmers looking for alternatives to wheat. Looking ahead, sustained high fertilizer costs could reduce application rates from 2027, weighing on yields. Even so, strong supply fundamentals are expected to keep agricultural commodity price rallies in check.

India aims for cocoa self-sufficiency by 2040

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

A knowledge paper on the cocoa sector, developed by Grant Thornton Bharat in collaboration with FICCI and released at the Cocoa Roundtable, outlined a long-term vision to transform India into a self-sufficient, globally competitive cocoa economy by 2040-41. The 2026-40 roadmap towards *Aatmanirbhar Bharat* in cocoa recommended the establishment of a ‘National Mission on Cocoa’ and the need for research and development (R&D) and innovation in the sector. It also suggested policy and financial support measures, as well as trade and market reforms, in addition to digital transformation in the sector.

THREE PHASES

In the first phase (2026-28),

the paper calls for launching a National Cocoa Mission and setting up a Centre of Excellence (CoE). It also proposes establishing about 250 hectares of polyclonal seed gardens across States. The second phase (2028-30) focuses on capacity building, including setting up regional CoE hubs and training nearly 1 lakh farmers. It also targets distribution of around 25 million seedlings and proposes a pilot digital farmer registry and traceability system. The third phase (2030-35) aims to expand cocoa cultivation to 1 lakh hectares and improve yields. It calls for scaling up R&D and promoting cocoa processing, with a goal of meeting 50 per cent of domestic demand through local production. The paper envisioned that India should be self-sufficient in cocoa production during the final phase (2035-

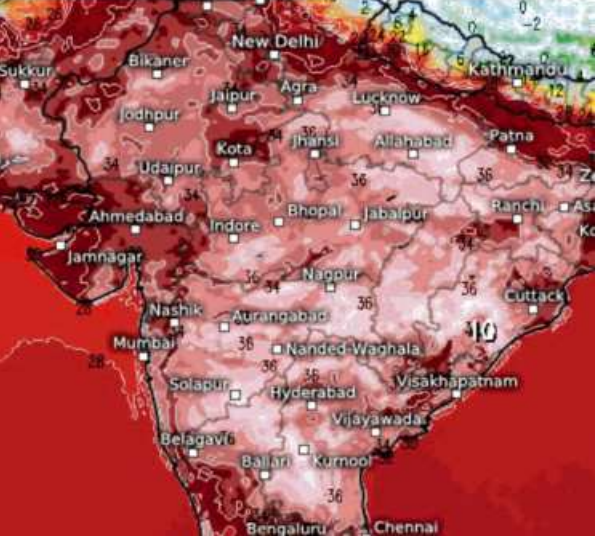
40) and be promoted as a global cocoa processing hub. This should also be the phase where farmers’ incomes improve significantly. The paper also recommended implementing 100 per cent digital traceability during the period. **GROWTH IN OFFTAKE** The knowledge paper said that domestic demand is expected to rise at a CAGR of 5.5 per cent, with consumption reaching 4.67 lakh tonnes of cocoa beans by 2040, while India currently meets less than 20 per cent of its total requirement. This structural shortfall has pushed India into heavy reliance on imports, with annual inflows exceeding \$866 million. A media statement said that the roundtable on ‘India’s Cocoa Future: Self Sufficiency and Global Value Chain Integration’ was held in New Delhi with the launch

of the knowledge paper, ‘Empowering the cocoa sector: A strategic roadmap for driving Aatmanirbhar Bharat through sustainable farming’. Speaking on the occasion, Naveen Kumar Patle, Additional Commissioner (Horticulture), Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, said cocoa, a largely import-dependent crop, faces key challenges in production and post-harvest management in India. Syed Junaid Altaf, Chairperson, FICCI Task Force on Horticulture and Group Executive Director, FIL, said cocoa had significant untapped potential to raise farm incomes, deepen agri-industry linkages and drive value-added, export-led growth. Chirag Jain, Partner at Grant Thornton Bharat, emphasised the need for stronger value-chain collaboration.

Central, East India brace for heatwave

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

The anti-cyclonic circulation over Karnataka and adjoining Maharashtra will drive heatwave conditions over isolated pockets of Central India across the western and eastern parts, according to an update by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Wednesday. The national forecasting agency said heatwave conditions may prevail over pockets of Telangana and Rayalaseema for the next four days, Madhya Maharashtra on Wednesday, north interior Karnataka for three days until Friday, and Marathwada for two days until Friday. **HOT AND HUMID** These conditions may also persist over Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha and Chhattisgarh for four days from tomorrow (Thursday until Sunday), over Odisha till Monday, and over west Rajasthan and Jharkhand on Friday and Saturday, the IMD said.



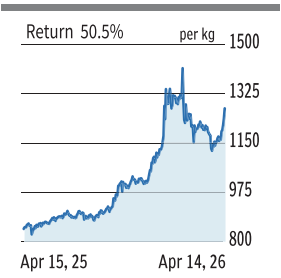
RISING MERCURY. Heat wave conditions may spread out across Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha, Chhattisgarh, Odisha and Jharkhand WWW.METEOLGIX.COM/IN

harashtra on Wednesday, coastal areas of east Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh for the next four days, and over coastal Karnataka on Wednesday. **MORE SOLUTIONS** Vishwas Chitale, Fellow at the New Delhi-based public policy think-tank Council on Energy, Environment and Water, said India’s extreme heat crisis needs structural solutions, not just emergency responses. “We urgently need to mainstream solutions such as cool roofs, net-zero cooling shelters and parametric insurance to protect our most vulnerable communities and outdoor workforces. Only by integrating climate data into city-level infrastructure will we be able to effectively tackle this invisible disaster and safeguard India’s public health and economic productivity,” he said.

Buy copper futures if the price dips to ₹1,250

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Copper futures, after appreciating 4.8 per cent last week, are up about 6 per cent so far this week. The April contract is now hovering around ₹1,280 per kg. The price action shows that the uptrend retains good momentum, and the probability of the contract scaling further up is high. The nearest notable resistance is the price region between ₹1,320 and ₹1,335. If copper futures breaks out of the latter, the uptrend could extend to ₹1,400. However, if the contract falls off the above-mentioned resistance band, it could drop to ₹1,250. A breakdown below this could turn the outlook negative, opening the door for a decline to ₹1,220. Either way, copper futures



is likely to rise towards the price band of ₹1,320 and ₹1,335. Although the chances for a rally are high, the risk-reward ratio is unfavourable for fresh longs. Traders are suggested to wait for a corrective decline. **TRADE STRATEGY** Buy copper futures (April) only if the price dips to ₹1,250. Place initial stop-loss at ₹1,220. When the contract rallies to ₹1,300, raise the stop-loss to ₹1,275. Book profits at ₹1,320.

TRI launches agri-voltaic project to help farmers earn more by energising their farms

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Transform Rural India, a non-profit organisation, has launched an agri-voltaics project to help farmers generate solar energy while continuing to grow crops on the same land, particularly in Jharkhand. “We have done more than 800 community-managed systems for irrigation. There are more than 100 villages with a community-managed solar structure. There are 140 community-managed microgrids,” said Ashok Kumar, Director - Farm Prosperity, Transform Rural India (TRI). With TRI’s guidance, farmers set up a microgrid and rent it out. Below the grid, they cultivate crops, while the power generated



Ashok Kumar, Director - Farm Prosperity, Transform Rural India

from the grid helps them to “energise” their farms and get a double income. **LOW INVESTMENT** For example, in Uttar Pradesh, where TRI also works, a 43-kw system has been set up and is connected to 10 pumps irrigating 100 acres and benefiting 160 farmers. “The one-time investment is less than ₹50,000 per

household. Their carbon footprint is low. The per-acre costs under diesel method come to about ₹6,000-7,000. The solar grid has reduced the cost to less than ₹2,000 per hour,” said Kumar. The project has encouraged them to go for drip irrigation and mulching, he said. **EXPOSURE VISIT** In Jharkhand, where the project is more focused, the organisation goes about identifying villages that are not served by power grid connections. TRI staff go to these villages and talk to the locals or women’s self-help groups. Once the farmers decide to set up a grid, the next task is to find the right location as per the criteria stipulated by the organisation. They will have to offer three options so that the best can be selected.

After that, a village energy committee (VCE) is formed, which enters into an agreement with the land owner to decide on the terms of trade and tariff. **IMPROVEMENT** Kumar said energy supply improves the livelihood, brings a feel good factor and a sense of dignity to the village. It helps improve children’s education and provides safety. He said that the grids are designed to meet needs for the next 5-10 years. The energy generated goes mainly for economic purposes such as irrigation, rice hullers and flour mills. The project has helped more than 20,000 farmers in Jharkhand. Besides, the TRI has launched a project in Uttar Pradesh, where 100 acres are irrigated.

Lower carat gold jewellery to gain traction this Akshaya Tritiya

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

After a steady rise over the past two years, gold prices have started easing since February, even amid uncertainty stemming from the ongoing West Asia conflict and rising geopolitical tensions. Gold prices have declined 18 per cent from their all-time high of ₹1.8 lakh per 10 g recorded in January to ₹1.52 lakh on Wednesday. Prices are expected to remain range-bound, with depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar acting as a key influence.

CHEAPER OPTIONS At current levels, 18-carat gold, priced around ₹1.16 lakh per 10 g, is nearly 24 per cent cheaper than 22-carat ornament gold, while 14-carat gold is about 40 per cent cheaper at ₹90,940. Consumer confidence in the yellow metal remains firm, with gold prices having risen 59 per cent from ₹94,611 per 10 g recorded during last year’s Akshaya Tritiya. Rajesh Rokde, Chairman of the All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council, said, “We expect demand for these lower carat categories to be higher this Akshaya Tritiya, along with lighter designs, despite the price surge.” Investors, meanwhile, are adopting a cautious approach, opting for lower-carat gold purchases amid uncertainty over future price movement, particularly once the situation in West Asia stabilises. Saurabh Gadgil, Chairman and MD of PNG Jewellers, said that despite elevated prices, consumer interest remains resilient and overall demand is expected to grow 25-30 per cent compared to



last year. “We have rolled out special festive campaigns across key markets including Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra, offering customer-centric benefits on old gold exchange and making charges,” he added. Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said 18-carat gold, offering 75 per cent purity at meaningfully lower price points, is emerging as a practical and aspirational middle ground, especially among the younger, design-conscious consumers. Nitesh Jain, Co-founder of Ethera, a BlueStone-backed lab-grown jewellery brand, said consumers were increasingly seeking designs that are versatile, wearable and more accessible at current gold prices. **GOLD ETFs SHINE** Beyond jewellery, gold investments through exchange-traded funds (ETFs) are also gaining traction and may serve as an additional option ahead of Akshaya Tritiya. Tapan Patel, Fund Manager - Commodities at Tata Asset Management, said gold ETFs in India had delivered returns of about 59 per cent from last year’s Akshaya Tritiya to date, helping protect investor value during this period.

CM
YK

